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Cong. slams Centre's stance on Chabahar

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RESPECTABLE DEATH

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Antonelli wins maiden title in Mercedes I-2

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NEARBY



Criticisms over cash transfers ironic: Minister

CHENNAI
Rejecting criticism over cash transfer schemes, Finance Minister Thangam Thennarasu has said it was ironic that they are portrayed as irresponsible only when implemented in Tamil Nadu. » PAGE 2

Larger drop in voters post SIR in urban areas

CHENNAI
Urban Assembly constituencies in Tamil Nadu appear to have undergone a substantial reduction in the size of their electorate when compared to rural seats in 2026. » PAGE 2

EDUCATION PLUS » PAGE 15

Assembly polls begin on April 9; West Bengal to vote in two phases

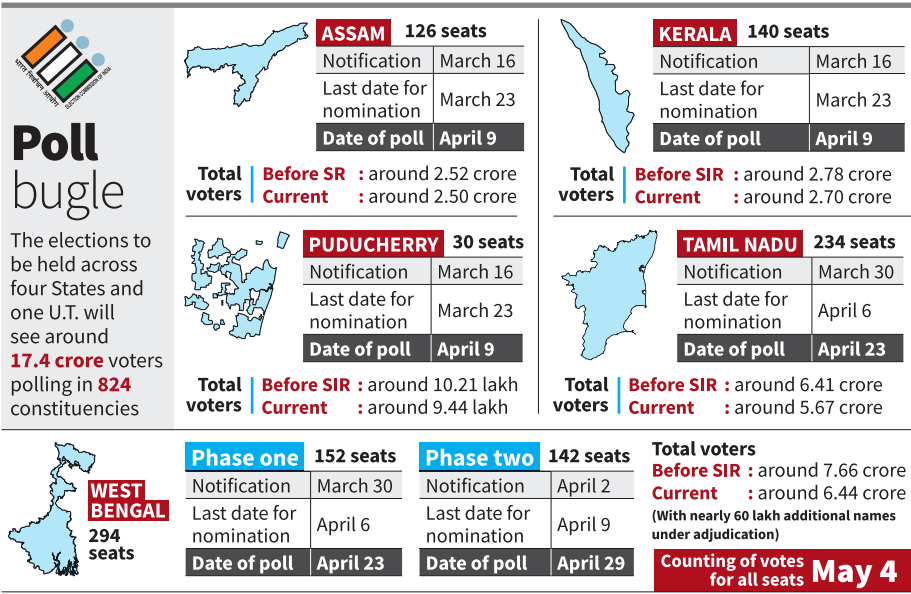
Polling will be held in Assam, Puducherry, and Kerala on April 9 and in Tamil Nadu on April 23, while West Bengal will vote on April 23 and 29; poll panel announces byelections to eight Assembly seats in various States; counting of votes on May 4

Sreeparna Chakrabarty
NEW DELHI

The Assembly elections will be held in a single phase in Assam, Puducherry, and Kerala on April 9 and in Tamil Nadu on April 23, while West Bengal will vote in two phases on April 23 and 29, the Election Commission of India (EC) announced on Sunday.

Counting for all four States and the Union Territory will be held on May 4. The Model Code of Conduct has come into effect with the announcement of the poll schedule.

At a press conference here, Chief Election Commissioner Gyanesh Kumar said around 17.4 crore electors would vote in 824 Assembly constituencies across the four States and



one Union Territory.

In West Bengal, 152 constituencies will vote in the first phase and 142 in the second.

The commission an-

nounced byelections to eight Assembly constituencies in various States. Five of the eight Assembly seats will vote on April 9 and remaining three will vote on

April 23. Counting of votes for the bypolls will also be held on May 4.

CONTINUED ON
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Parties welcome fewer poll phases in West Bengal

KOLKATA
With the 2021 Assembly election having been held in eight phases, major political parties in West Bengal have welcomed the two-phase Assembly polls announced for the State on Sunday. » PAGE 9

LDF swings into action in Kerala with list of names

THIRUVANANTHAPURAM
The ruling Left Democratic Front in Kerala sought to steal a march on the Congress-led United Democratic Front, with its two major alliance partners announcing their candidates on Sunday. » PAGE 5

A polling booth in Tamil Nadu stands out with just 5 voters

The Hindu Bureau
CHENNAI

When Tamil Nadu votes in the Assembly election on April 23, one polling booth atop a hill in the southern part of the State will stand out. A polling booth will be established at Vellimalai in Varusanadu in Theni district to help just five voters exercise their franchise.

Polling officials would have to travel three hours through a difficult terrain to reach the booth, which found a mention at a press conference addressed by Chief Election Commissioner Gyanesh Kumar in New Delhi on Sunday to announce the Assembly election schedule.

Model Code kicks in
Consequent to the announcement of the election schedule, the Model Code of Conduct (MCC) came into force in Tamil Nadu in the evening, Chief Electro-

Polling officials will have to travel three hours to reach the booth at Vellimalai in Theni district

ral Officer Archana Patnaik said.

It would be applicable to all candidates, political parties, and the State and Union governments, she said.

The MCC would be in force for more than one-and-a-half months.

According to an official release from the Election Commission, District Election Officers (DEOs) have been directed to obtain information on unusual and suspicious withdrawal or deposit of cash exceeding ₹1 lakh at banks for due verification, followed by necessary action.

CONTINUED ON
» PAGE 2

LPG bookings fall to 77 lakh, hinting let-up in panic-buying

Press Trust of India
NEW DELHI

Bookings for liquefied petroleum gas (LPG) refills have declined to about 77 lakh on Saturday from 88.8 lakh the day before, indicating some easing of panic-buying, even as the government said there is no shortage of petrol, diesel, or cooking gas, and supplies remain stable despite the West Asia conflict.

All domestic "refineries are operating at high capacity and maintaining adequate crude oil inventories", the Centre said on Sunday in its daily update on the impact of the West Asia situation. "The country remains self-sufficient in the production of petrol and diesel, requiring no



People queue with their LPG cylinders at a dealership in Patna on Sunday. ANI

imports of the fuels to meet domestic demand."

Oil marketing companies have reported no dry-outs at fuel retail outlets or LPG distributors, and petrol, diesel, and LPG supplies are being maintained regularly, it said.

An Indian-flagged crude

tanker, *Jag Laadki*, sailed out safely from Fujairah in the UAE on Sunday morning after loading 80,800 tonnes of Murban crude oil, despite an attack on the oil terminal. All crew members of the India-bound vessel are safe, the government said. *Jag Laadki* is the fourth Indian-flagged vessel to have come out of the war zone unharmed.

The government said it continued to prioritise domestic consumers and ensure uninterrupted LPG supply, particularly for households and priority sectors such as hospitals and educational institutions.

CONTINUED ON
» PAGE 8

Not ready for deal, might hit Kharg 'for fun', says Trump

Agence France-Presse
WASHINGTON

U.S. President Donald Trump has warned that he is not ready to seek a deal to end the war with Iran, as U.S. ally Israel launched a new wave of strikes on Sunday, more than two weeks into the conflict in West Asia.

Mr. Trump, in an interview, said he thought Tehran was keen to come to the table but that Washington would fight on for better terms and might bomb targets on Iran's Kharg Island "a few more times just for fun".

FULL REPORT ON
» PAGE 12

7 from T.N. on pilgrimage in Nepal die in road accident

The Hindu Bureau
CHENNAI

Seven pilgrims from Tamil Nadu died and seven others were injured after the vehicle in which they were travelling met with an accident in Nepal on Saturday, officials said in Chennai on Sunday.

Senior officials of the State government were coordinating with officials in the Tamil Nadu House in New Delhi and those of the Ministry of External Affairs to bring home the injured, who were treated at a hospital.

CONTINUED ON
» PAGE 2

TSP Battalion Commandant held for sexual harassment

The Hindu Bureau
COIMBATORE

T. Senthil Kumar, 54, Commandant of the Tamil Nadu Special Police (TSP) IV Battalion at Kovaipudur in Coimbatore, was arrested on sexual harassment charges on Saturday.

A release from the Coimbatore City Police said high-ranking officials in the department received sexual harassment complaints against Mr. Kumar in December 2025 and January 2026.

Complaints sent to ICC
These complaints were forwarded to an Internal Complaints Committee (ICC). Following an investigation conducted under

An order, dated February 12, 2026, said it was necessary in the public interest to place the commandant under suspension

the leadership of a woman police officer in the rank of Deputy Inspector-General of Police, the ICC recommended Mr. Kumar's suspension from service.

Consequently, the Home Department placed Mr. Kumar under suspension under Rule 17(e) of the Tamil Nadu Civil Services (Discipline and Appeal) Rules, 1955, in February. An order, dated February 12, 2026, said it was neces-

sary in the public interest to place the commandant under suspension in the circumstances of the case.

Case registered
Emboldened by the action of the committee, a police-woman lodged a complaint of sexual harassment against Mr. Kumar at the All-Women Police Station, Coimbatore South, on March 12.

A case was registered against Mr. Kumar, who was summoned for questioning and arrested on Saturday. He was lodged at the Coimbatore Central Prison.

The police added that two special teams were continuing the investigation in the case.



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M CH-CH

From Page One

A polling booth in the State stands out with just 5 voters

“If the amount is more than ₹10 lakh, DEOs shall pass on such information to the Income Tax Department for necessary action. FIU-IND [Financial Intelligence Unit-India] has been requested to share Cash Transaction Reports (CTRs) and Suspicious Transaction Reports (STRs) with CBDT [the Central Board of Direct Taxes] for effective monitoring of the election expenditure of the candidates,” the release said.

End of current Assembly’s term

The term of the 16th Tamil Nadu Assembly will end on May 10. As on March 15, the total number of electors in the State is 5,67,74,436, including 5,67,07,380 general electors and 67,056 service voters.

Over 12.51 lakh of them are in the 18-19 age group, and there are 2,530 centenarian electors. About 3.99 lakh of them are aged 85 or older and over 1.05 crore of them are aged 20-29.

There are 75,032 polling booths, including 44,065 in rural areas and 30,967 in urban areas.

Average number of electors per booth

The average number of electors per booth is 756. Of the total number of booths, 265 have been marked as model booths, and 258 would be managed by women. Webcasting would be arranged at all the booths.

Of the 234 Assembly constituencies, 44 are reserved for candidates of the Scheduled Castes and two are reserved for candidates of the Scheduled Tribes.

Seven persons from T.N. on pilgrimage in Nepal die in road accident

The deceased were identified as Annamalai, Vijayal, Meenakshi, Sivakami, Muthu Kumar, Meena, and Tamilarasi.

The accident happened in Gorkha district of Gandaki Province, the State government said in a release.

Residents of Pollachi and Devakottai

A total of 24 pilgrims from Pollachi and Devakottai travelled to the Manakamana Temple in Gorkha district.

“After the autopsy, the bodies are being taken to Kathmandu, from where they will be sent to Chennai. Efforts are being made to transport the mortal remains to the native places of the deceased,” the release said.

T.N.’s urban areas record higher fall in number of voters than rural ones

T. Ramakrishnan
CHENNAI

Urban Assembly constituencies in Tamil Nadu appeared to have undergone a substantial reduction in their size of electorate than rural seats in 2026, post the Special Intensive Revision (SIR) of voter roll undertaken by the Election Commission of India (EC).

A comparative perusal of the data of 30 select Assembly constituencies in the State reveals Thousand Lights, Velachery, and T. Nagar, all in Chennai, are some of the areas that suffered a reduction in electorate to the extent of over 30%. Among other urban seats that have seen a considerable fall are Coimbatore (South) – 23.83% and Kolathur, represented by DMK leader and Chief Minister M.K. Stalin – 28.3%. One reason generally cited is the high prevalence of migration of people in cities and towns, a feature that is not as rampant in rural areas as is the case with urban.

For the purpose of this study, the Assembly constituency-wise data, as on January 5, 2025, and as on February 23, 2026, have been considered. At the time of launch of SIR in October last year, the electorate of the State went up by about 5 lakh. In other words, the overall figure stood at about 6.41 crore, whereas it was 6.36 crore at the time of the completion of special summary revision in January 2025. The constituency-wise data, as

Electoral roll clean-up	Constituency	Jan. 2025 roll (as on Jan. 5)	Post-SIR roll (as on Feb. 23, 2026)	Reduction	
				Number	In %
The table shows the pattern of changes in the number of voters in select Assembly constituencies across Tamil Nadu following the Special Intensive Revision	Avadi	4,60,408	4,28,772	31,636	6.88
	Tiruvottiyur	2,85,656	2,40,586	45,070	15.78
	Kolathur	2,88,937	2,07,251	81,686	28.30
	Thousand Lights	2,38,475	1,53,908	84,567	35.50
	T. Nagar	2,35,616	1,54,943	80,673	34.24
	Velachery	3,16,642	2,11,691	1,04,951	33.15
	Sriperumpudur (SC)	4,00,180	3,75,921	24,259	6.06
	Vellore	2,51,965	2,11,063	40,902	16.23
	Gudiyatham (SC)	3,02,758	2,48,526	54,232	17.90
	Villupuram	2,65,469	2,44,080	21,389	8.06
	Hosur	3,61,411	3,38,295	23,116	6.40
	Dharmapuri	2,68,424	2,57,939	10,485	3.90
	Edappadi	2,90,158	2,74,054	16,104	5.55
	Salem (West)	3,05,908	2,55,320	50,588	16.54
	Erode (West)	3,01,116	2,45,493	55,623	18.47
	Gudalur (SC)	1,95,312	1,83,888	11,424	5.85
	Kavundampalayam	4,91,143	4,07,507	83,636	11.32
	Coimbatore (South)	2,44,863	1,86,509	58,354	23.83
	Srirangam	3,12,029	2,83,862	28,167	9.02
	Tiruchi (West)	2,77,018	2,35,903	41,115	14.84
	Kilvelur (SC)	1,76,505	1,68,934	7,571	4.30
	Thiruthuraiipoondi (SC)	2,41,037	2,25,363	15,674	6.50
	Kumbakonam	2,72,378	2,51,868	20,510	7.53
	Thirumayam	2,38,242	2,19,279	18,963	7.96
	Madurai (East)	3,49,612	3,30,993	18,619	5.33
	Madurai (West)	3,08,689	2,71,341	37,348	12.10
	Srivilliputhur (SC)	2,40,402	2,22,367	18,035	7.50
	Mudukalathur	3,18,037	2,97,310	20,727	6.52
	Ottapidaram (SC)	2,53,593	2,40,988	12,605	4.97
	Nagercoil	2,68,809	2,57,022	11,787	4.40
	Total	87,60,792	76,30,976	11,29,816	12.90
	Overall State	6,36,12,950	5,67,07,380	69,05,570	10.86

on January 2025, have been considered, as only it is available in the public domain and not that of October 2025, when enrolment of electors was frozen temporarily. As far as the study is concerned, the reduction in the electorate in the selected 30 constituencies is 12.9% against 10.86% for the entire State.

Looking at the overall picture, urban constituencies in northern and western districts have experienced a perceptible decrease, whereas those in the central and southern regions have seen a moderate decline. Among the minimum changes recorded by the seats are Nagercoil, Madurai (East), Kilvelur,

and Dharmapuri. Of the seven chosen constituencies reserved for Scheduled Castes, the general trend is that the reduction (ranging from 7.5% in Srivilliputhur to 4.97% in Ottapidaram) is lower than the State average of 12.9%. The outlier is Gudiyatham in the northern belt, where the degree of reduction is 17.9%.

INTERVIEW

Thangam
Thenmarasu

Sangeetha Kandavel

With the Assembly election set for April 23, the debate on welfare spending, public debt, and fiscal priorities has moved to the centre of political discourse. In an interview to The Hindu, senior DMK leader and Finance Minister Thangam Thenmarasu explains the rationale behind the welfare model and addresses criticism over cash transfer schemes. Edited excerpts:

Critics have dubbed as politically motivated the DMK government’s recent act of transferring a lump sum to the bank accounts of beneficiaries of welfare schemes ahead of the election. They are also pointing to the increased debt burden. What’s your response?

Welfare spending in itself is not a negative. If the benefits of economic growth are not broad-based, the fruits of development will inevitably be cornered by a small section of society. Our approach in Tamil Nadu has always been to ensure that growth is inclusive and its benefits reach every household. Cash transfer schemes, at one point of time, were widely regarded as one of the most effective policy interventions. Economists and development experts across the

world have recognised that such a direct transfer reduces leakages, provides autonomy to beneficiaries in deciding how best to utilise the support, and stimulates local and rural economies through increased consumption. The Union government came up with the PM-KISAN scheme. There are 15 States that are implementing cash transfer schemes for women. It is somewhat ironic that when such policies are implemented in Tamil Nadu, they are suddenly portrayed as fiscally irresponsible or politically motivated. Over the last five years, this government has spent more than ₹4 lakh crore on welfare programmes and social support measures.

So what has been the economic return or social impact of major welfare programmes introduced in the last five years?

The monthly entitlement given to women under the Kalaiginar Magalir Urimai Thogai scheme has strengthened their financial independence and improved household financial stability. The Pudhumai Penn scheme has led to a significant improvement in college enrolment among girl students of government schools. If you look at Vidiyal Payanam Thittam, there is a clear increase in the number of bus trips made by women passengers, reflecting improved mobility and greater access to employment and educational opportunities. According to a 2023 study, households have been able



Huge allocation: The Finance Minister says the DMK government has spent over ₹4 lakh crore on welfare programmes and social support measures over the last five years. B. JOTHI RAMALINGAM

to save around ₹888 a month, on an average, owing to the reduced transport cost.

Can Tamil Nadu continue such a welfare model without pushing future generations into deeper debt?

I don’t believe we are getting into a debt-trap. The growth in debt over the last five years has been about 96%, whereas during the previous five-year period, it was about 128%. At the same time, our debt-to-GSDP ratio remains within manageable limits and broadly within the trajectory recommended by the Finance Commission of India. When it comes to welfare spending, I would like to place it in the broader context of the growth model of Tamil Nadu. History teaches us that the most important factor of production is human capital. As economies develop and the demographic dividend gradually diminishes, the central economic challenge shifts towards improving productivity. Ensuring individuals are healthier, better educated and economically empo-

wered, therefore, becomes essential. Our welfare and social sector programmes are designed precisely with this objective in mind. The scale of this investment has been substantial.

Our expenditure on health, education, and social welfare over the last five years has been significantly higher than in the earlier periods, reflecting the government’s commitment to strengthening human and social capital. In that sense, the resources we are deploying today should not be viewed as a burden on future generations. Rather, they are investments that will enable them to inherit a stronger economy, a more productive workforce, and a more capable society.

The DMK government has frequently voiced concern about the Union government’s financial policies. Had Tamil Nadu received a larger share of Central funds, how differently would the State budget have looked?

The numbers would look very different. In fact, we probably would not even

be having this conversation. Tamil Nadu’s share in the divisible pool of Central taxes has declined from 7.932% under the Ninth Finance Commission to 4.079% under the Fifteenth Finance Commission. This has largely been due to an excessive emphasis on redistribution that ends up penalising progressive and better-performing states.

Had Tamil Nadu continued to receive the same share of Central taxes as during the Ninth Finance Commission period, our debt today would be at least 32% lower. In addition to this, delays or withholding of funds under Central government-sponsored schemes, such as the Jal Jeevan Mission, Samagra Shiksha Abhiyan and MGNREGA, have added to the State’s fiscal burden. If we consider these withheld amounts along with the associated interest cost, they would account for roughly 40%-45% of our current debt. In an ideal scenario, if Tamil Nadu were to receive a larger and more equitable share of Central funds, the State’s debt could be closer to ₹6 lakh crore. That would have created substantial fiscal space for us to invest more in infrastructure, human development, and other key priorities of the State.

The State Economic Survey indicates that Tamil Nadu can achieve a one-trillion-dollar economy milestone by around 2030-31. What are your views?

Tamil Nadu’s economy is

currently estimated to be around \$450 billion. If the State is to reach the one-trillion-dollar milestone by 2030-31, we require an annual growth rate of approximately 17%-18% in nominal dollar terms. When we factor in an average inflation of around 4%-5% and an expected rupee depreciation of about 1%-2% annually, the economy would need to sustain roughly 10%-11% real growth each year to reach the mark. Given that the State has already achieved a real growth of about 11.19% in 2024-25, I believe this target, while ambitious, is certainly not unachievable if the current growth momentum continues.

Looking back at your tenure as the Finance Minister, what has been your most difficult budget decision?

Every budget inevitably involves difficult choices because resources are limited while expectations and development needs are vast. I wouldn’t call them difficult, but one of the most challenging decisions has been the announcement of the Tamil Nadu Assured Pension Scheme.

This was particularly challenging decision because the pension commitments have significant long-term fiscal implications for the government. Any reform in this area is usually a once-in-a-generation measure. It must carefully balance the legitimate expectations of government employees with the need to ensure long-term fiscal sustainability for the State.

Assembly election 2026: campaign window set at 38 days, same as in 2021

N. Sai Charan
CHENNAI

With the announcement of the Tamil Nadu Assembly election schedule on Sunday, political parties will get a 38-day window to undertake campaigning, which will end at 5 p.m. on April 21, before polling is held on April 23. This period is crucial for parties contesting in alliances, as they will have to finalise seat-sharing numbers, identify constituencies, select candidates, file nominations, release manifestos, and draw up campaign itineraries.

The window for campaigning in this election is the same as that of the 2021 Assembly election, which was held amid the COVID-19 pandemic. Five years ago, the Election Commission of India (EC) had announced the schedule on February 26, and polling in Tamil Nadu took place on April 6, effectively giving candidates an identical 38-day period to reach out to voters. However, earlier electoral cycles afforded parties a significantly longer campaign period. In 2016, candidates had over 70 days to campaign, while in 2011 the campaign period was over 40 days. Further, the 2026 election cycle represents Tamil Nadu’s most compressed poll schedule since 2011. This means the administrative freeze on announcing new policies and schemes or

Set for poll

The table shows a comparison of the last four Assembly election schedules in Tamil Nadu

Assembly election year	2011	2016	2021*	2026
	Poll announcement March 1	March 4	February 26	March 15
Issue of Notification	March 19	April 22	March 12	March 30
Date of polling	April 13	May 16	April 6	April 23
Counting of votes	May 13	May 19	May 2	May 4

*Elections held amid COVID-19 pandemic

floating tenders during the Model Code of Conduct will be relatively brief.

From the date of announcement to the counting of votes on May 4, the entire process spans 51 days in this election. In comparison, the time frame stretched to 66 days in 2021, 77 days in 2016, and 74 days in 2011. The gap between polling of votes and counting, during which the Electronic Voting Machines will be kept in strongrooms under tight security and EC supervision, has been reduced from 25 days in 2021 to 10 days this time.

For both alliances led by

DMK steps up seat-sharing discussions with allies

B. Kolappan
CHENNAI

With the announcement of the Tamil Nadu Assembly election schedule, the ruling DMK is speeding up seat-sharing with allies such as the CPI, CPI(M), VCK, and the new constituency DMKD.

While the Left parties have insisted on more seats than the six each they were given in 2021, the DMK leadership is citing constraints due to alliance expansion. The talks between the DMK and the Left parties will resume on March 17, as the DMK is holding its district secretaries’ meeting on Monday. Sources said the DMK may allot five seats each to the CPI and the CPI(M) and also restrict the number for the DMDK to a single digit as the party’s nominee L.K. Sudhish was given a Rajya Sabha berth. As for the Congress, the DMK had given it 28, three more than last time. “The DMDK is demanding seats in two digits, but we are unable to concede to its demands,” a source said. VCK leaders say at least 10 seats would justify the party’s strength and convince the cadre. The DMK, however, is inclined to allot it eight seats, up from six from last time.

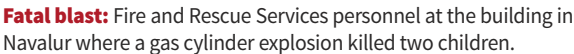
The DMK leadership refused to believe that actor-TVK founder Vijay would join the AIADMK-BJP alliance. A senior DMK leader said Mr. Vijay would not accept the deal as it would expose him thoroughly.

Two children killed, 7 persons injured in gas cylinder explosion in Navalur

The Hindu Bureau
CHENNAI

In the impact of the explosion, the building col-

Vairamuthu, who operates a catering service supplying food to hostels nearby, his wife Selvi, and their 7-year-old son Pradeep lived in one of the houses. In the second house, Sanjeev Kumar-Sonia couple



house in the building was occupied by a person named Murugan. As the residential units crumbled, all those residing in them

The personnel put out the fire and started rescuing the survivors trapped under the rubble. But, two children – Krithika and Theeran – had died. Sanjeev Kumar, Sonia, Chitra, Vairamuthu, Selvi, Pradeep, and Murugan sustained burns.

Vairamuthu, his wife Selvi, and their son Praadeep sustained severe burns in the incident.

Newborn injured as warmer catches fire in Corpn. hospital

On Saturday, Dhana-lakshmi delivered a baby boy at the Corporation maternity hospital located on Kariyappa Street in Purasawalkam. The medical staff in the hospital placed the baby inside a warmer machine to regulate his body

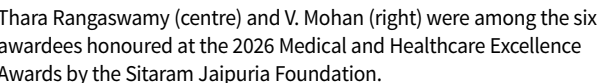
A senior official of the Health Department of the Chennai Corporation said the injured baby is being treated. The health officials have been directed to check all warmer machines installed in Corporation hospitals.

Temporary professors stage protest over removal from service

With no experience certificate or no objection certificate from the university, the teachers now are not eligible to apply for other jobs.

2 Chennai specialists among winners of healthcare awards

V. Mohan, chairman of Dr. Mohan's Diabetes Specialities Centre and chairman of the Madras Dia-



Research Foundation, was conferred the Shri Ashwini Kumar Award for Healthcare Excellence in Diabetes and Obesity Care for his contributions to advancing clinical care, research, and innovation in diabetes management. Both these

The honours instituted by the Sitaram Jaipuria Foundation aims to recognise healthcare professionals whose work has significantly impacted clinical practice, research, policy and public health.

Autorickshaw driver killed as car rams his vehicle in Vadapalani

The police said Bhaskar was a resident of VOCC Street in Mathiyazhagan Nagar of Saligramam and was an autorickshaw driver. On Saturday night, Bhaskar was returning home in his autorickshaw on the Vadapalani - Ner-

In the accident, the authorickshaw was completely damaged and Bhaskar died on the spot. Pondy Bazaar Traffic Investigation police sent the body to the Government Kilpauk Medical College Hospital for post-mortem. The police are checking the CCTV footage to identify the car driver.



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17	151/3	51
18	156/3	21
TOTAL.		442.00

INBRIEF



DMK will stand by Muslims and their rights, says Stalin

Chief Minister M.K. Stalin on Sunday said the DMK would stand by Muslims and speak for their rights irrespective of whether it was in power or not. “We have moved resolutions in the Assembly in support of them and fought cases in the courts,” he said at an Iftar feast held by the party’s minority wing. He alleged though leaders, including AIADMK general secretary Edappadi K. Palaniswami, participated in Iftar feasts, they remained mute spectators when Muslims faced problems from the BJP government. Meanwhile, speaking after another Iftar feast, AIADMK general secretary Edappadi K. Palaniswami said neither the AIADMK nor its allies had held alliance talks with actor-turned-politician Vijay’s TVK for the Assembly election.

Tamilaga Valvurimai Katchi to reconsider alliance with DMK

Tamilaga Valvurimai Katchi founder T. Velmurugan on Sunday said the party would reconsider its decision to go with the DMK in the Assembly election as the Dravidian major rejected its demand for more seats. Besides, the DMK had not acknowledged the party’s 10-point demand including 10.5% internal reservation for Vanniyaars with the MBC quota. He said the party was open to tying up with the AIADMK also, if its demands are accepted. Mr. Velmurugan said, while he was averse to sharing a platform with the BJP, he was open to have a seat-sharing arrangement with the AIADMK.

Frames tell stories at International Photography Open Call showcase

The Hindu Bureau
CHENNAI

With layers of colour, action and emotion, the second edition of the International Photography Open Call showcase came alive with stories galore in each frame at VR Chennai. Organised by the Chennai Photo Biennale Foundation, the showcase saw a total of 80 print and digital photographs on display. Among Thakur, an artist from Bengaluru, said, “What I want people to take away from the exhibition is that AI is not a replacement for photography. AI can be a tool that you use, but it can’t be a replacement for art. When



People of all age groups from across 43 countries applied and a total of 9,400 pictures were submitted. A jury of eight members from all over the world selected the best entries. B. JOTHI RAMALINGAM

photography started, painting didn’t die. Art is resilient, perennial, and immortal.” Habeeb Rahman, a resident of Padi who visited the mall with his family,

was rather surprised to see the exhibit in a mall. “It is quite refreshing to see such an exhibit in a mall amidst gaming zones and retail outlets. This way, children will get exposed

to art,” he said. Varun Gupta, director of Chennai Photo Biennale Foundation, said, this is the second edition of the International Photography Open Call. People across

43 countries from all age groups applied and a total of 9,400 pictures were submitted. A jury of eight members from all over the world selected the best entries. The exhibit is part one (a single image showcase) of the two-part series. The second part will be a photo series which will open on 19 March at Avatar Foundation for the Arts, MRC Nagar. Both the exhibits will be held till 5 April. “We want to celebrate photography, make it accessible for people in public spaces. In a mall, thousands of people get to see it. What’s really special about this edition is we are seeing the quality of the

single image has significantly gone up. Whenever we intervene with art in public space, it’s been fantastic because you break the rhythm of someone’s daily life and give them an opportunity to discover something new,” he noted. Our goal is to put Chennai on the map of contemporary arts in the world, he said. Rangaprasad R., associate director for exhibitions for the foundation, said they have attempted to turn the event environment-friendly. “We have repurposed everything from flex boards to frames from the previous edition. This is our small initiative to be eco-friendly,” he said.

AIADMK overhauls governing council, forms seat-sharing committee for poll

The Hindu Bureau
CHENNAI

The AIADMK on Sunday reconstituted its governing council, and formed a seat-sharing committee for holding talks with its allies. The party also formed committees for election campaign, election publicity, legal matters, and media liaison. AIADMK general secretary Edappadi K. Palaniswami would be the chairperson of the governing council. The party’s president chairman, A. Tamil Magan Hussain; former Ministers K.P. Munusamy, Dindigul C. Sreenivasan, S.P. Velumani, and B. Valarmathi; P. Venugopal, A. Justin Selvaraj, and I.S. Inbadurai are the other members of the council. Mr. Munusamy, Mr. Sreenivasan, Mr. Velumani, and Ms. Valarmathi are also part of the seat-sharing committee.

Senior leaders M. Tham-bidurai, N. Thalavaisundaram, Sellur K. Raju, P. Dhanapal, K.P. Anbalagan, R. Kamaraj, S. Gokula Indira, P. Benjamin, Udumalai K. Radhakrishnan, and N.R. Sivapathi are part of the election campaign committee. Senior leaders C. Vijaya-baskar, Kadambur C. Raju, K.T. Rajenthra Bhalaji, Agri S.S. Krishnamurthy, Mr. Venugopal, S. Abdul Rahim, V.V.R. Raj Satyen, and V.M. Rajalakshmi have been appointed to the election publicity committee. The party has appointed C.Ve. Shanmugam, V.S. Sethuraman, Mr. Inbadurai, R.M. Babu Murugavel, and E. Balamurugan to the legal team. P. Thangamani, D.Jayakumar, R.B. Udhaya-kumar, S.S. Vaigaichelvan, V.P.B. Paramasivam, ‘Ma Foi’ Pandiarajan, and S. Kalyanasundaram are the members of the media liaison committee.

BJP government’s wrong decisions led to LPG cylinder shortage: Stalin

CHENNAI: Alleging that the BJP-led Union government’s wrong decisions had led to the LPG shortage in the country, Chief Minister M.K.

Stalin said on Sunday that it should come forward to resolve the issue. In a social media post, he said the Centre had earned the repu-

tation of being a “failure model” in the country’s foreign policy. “There is no vision. There have been no precautionary measures,” he said.



INTEGRAL COACH FACTORY



The following e-tenders are published in IREPS website. Firms are requested to login to www.ireps.gov.in and quote against these tenders. Manual quotation will not be entertained for this tender.

Sl. No.	OPEN TENDER NO.	SHORT DESCRIPTION OF WORK	APPROX. VALUE IN (₹)	DATE OF TENDER CLOSING DATE & TIME
1	2026377212157	(A) Re-conditioning of leak test plants near LHB, RT shed and shop 36 in Furnishing factory. (B) Providing RCC flooring for Open type rack clad Automated storage & Retrieval system (AS/RS) (C) Proposed shed of size 26m X 33m on Eastern side of shop C pit traverser in Shell factory	3.87 Crores	02.04.2026 @ 11.30 hrs
2	2026377212158	Proposed lifeline arrangement in Shop 30, 30A, 54, Dispatch shed and DPRS shed in Furnishing division.	5.39 Crores	02.04.2026 @ 15.30 hrs
3	2026377212155	(A) Retrofitting to G+7 quarters BLOCK No.1-42 unit of Type II quarters at South colony (B) Retrofitting to G+7 quarters BLOCK No.3-42 unit of Type II quarters at South colony	5.74 Crores	02.04.2026 @ 10.30 hrs
4	2026377212156	(A) Renewal of wornout 90R Rails, Inspection pit and Ballastless track at Shop 30 & 36 inside Furnishing factory. (B) Proposed extension of Road-1A, Road-1 & Road-3 for stabling capacity of 24 car rake in ICF VLK yard.	8.33 Crores	02.04.2026 @ 11.30 hrs
5	2026377212161	Improvements to track by welding of avoidable joints at Shell, Furnishing and ICF yard at Anna nagar & Villivakkam	1.98 Crores	04.04.2026 @ 10.30 hrs
6	2026377212162	(A) Operation and maintenance of RO plant of capacity 2000 LPH in Shop 30, Shop 36, Shop 54 and LHB, 1000 LPH in inside LHB, Sewage treatment plant of capacity 200 KLD, Cleaning of GLR, OHT and 30m3/Hr Pressure filter inside Furnishing Factory. (B) Operation and maintenance of RO plant of capacity 500 LPH in D&D building, 250 LPH in Furnishing workers canteen, Furnishing Admin office, CRM and 5 KLD ETP at Furnishing workers canteen. (C) Operation and maintenance of sewage treatment plant of capacity 60 KLD in South colony (D) Operation and Maintenance of RO plant of 250 LPH capacity at ICF officers Guest house, 500 LHB in Block No. 609 and 25m3/hour pressure filter arrangement in Perambur.	2.21 Crores	04.04.2026 @ 10.30 hrs

Hindi translation of the advertisement available in the website www.icf.indianrailways.gov.in

OBITUARY & REMEMBRANCE

DEATH



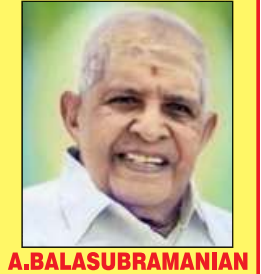
(1935-2026)
Shriromani Mrs Lakshmi Venkatasubramanian, also known as **T. R. Lakshmi**, wife of former Law Secretary, GOI, late Mr P. B. Venkatasubramanian, peacefully shuffled off this mortal coil on Saturday, **14 March 2026** at her home in Chennai.
A bulwark of strength, a patron of the arts and a matriarch to the countless she helped, she is mourned by her sons PV Balakrishnan and PV Rajagopalan, daughters in law Shobana and Sheila, five grandchildren, a great grandson, brother T.R. Srinivasan and extended family.
Mob 9841723748 / 9940095378

DEATH



K. SARASWATHY
retired teacher Vidyodaya Hr. Sec School, w/o late S. SIVAKUMARAN (AG's Office) expired on 13.03.2026.
Deeply Bereaved by
Family Members and Friends.
Hari & Anandhi
Ph : 7550177387

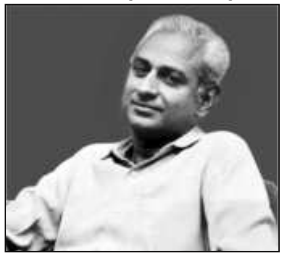
IN MEMORIAM



A. BALASUBRAMANIAN
Chartered Accountant, Chidambaram
22.08.1923 - 16.03.2015
Remembered By
Family Members, Partners & Staff
M/s.A. Balasubramanian
Chartered Accountants, Chidambaram, Karaikal & Bangalore

DEATH

In Loving Memory



GOPALAN NARAYANAN
Senior Advocate, Chennai
1 December 1935 - 13 March 2026
With gratitude for a life beautifully lived, we celebrate the memory and peaceful passing of Gopalan Narayanan (GN), aged 90, Senior Advocate, Chennai, on 13th March 2026 in Montreal, Canada, surrounded by his loving family.
A man of profound wisdom and a generously helpful spirit, GN was cherished for his warmth, his humour, and his remarkable ability to bring stories to life.
Beloved husband of **Gopi Yasoda**. Loving father of **Ashwin, Anupama** and **Aparna**; father-in-law of **Reena, Richard** and **Aanand**.
Cherished grandfather of **Dhruv, Tejas, Tara, Aarya, Saira** and **Ved**.
May he rest in eternal peace.









M CH-CHE

TDP MP, BRS ex-MLA ‘detained after drug raid’ in Telangana

The Hindu Bureau
HYDERABAD

Ten persons, including an MP from Andhra Pradesh and a former MLA from Telangana, were detained after narcotics were found during a raid at a farmhouse in Moinabad, Telangana on Saturday night. During the raid, officials reportedly seized about two grams of cocaine.

Those detained were Putta Mahesh Kumar, MP for Eluru representing the Telugu Desam Party (TDP); Pilot Rohith Reddy, former MLA and BRS leader; Moraganeni Ramesh, 49, a real estate businessman from Manikonda; V. Sravan Kumar, 40, a private employee from Manikonda; Namith Sharma, 42, associated with a construction company and residing in Delhi; Ritesh Reddy, 40, a businessman from Manikonda and brother of Rohith Reddy; Nallapuneni Vijaya Krishna, 49, a real estate businessman from Nanakramguda; Kaushik Ravi, 39, an advocate from Gachibowli; Arjun Reddy, 34, a businessman from Nanakramguda; and K. Sarayu Reddy, 34, a resident of Himayathnagar.

Judicial custody

Of the detained, Mr. Rohith Reddy, Mr. Ritesh Reddy and Mr. Namit Sharma were remanded to 14 days in judicial custody in Chanchalguda Jail until March 27. The other accused were granted station bail.

Preliminary drug tests conducted on those present showed that six of

The narcotic bust was carried out at a farmhouse belonging to former legislator Rohith Reddy

them had consumed narcotics, according to authorities. Those who tested positive included Mr. Rohith Reddy's brother Ritesh Reddy, Namith Sharma, Kaushik Ravi and Arjun Reddy, among others.

High drama unfolded during the raid, which was carried out by the Elite Action Group for Drug Law Enforcement (EAGLE) following a tip-off about a party involving narcotics at a farmhouse belonging to Mr. Rohith Reddy.

Rounds fired

Officials said the team initially faced resistance from security personnel and Mr. Rohith Reddy.

Police said that in the commotion during the raid, Mr. Namith Sharma allegedly fired three rounds into the air using a revolver in an attempt to evade the enforcement team.

Investigators eventually collected gunshot residue (GSR) samples, and the tests later identified Mr. Namith Sharma as the person who discharged the weapon, which belonged to Mr. Rohit Reddy's brother Ritesh Reddy.

EAGLE Director Sandeep Shandilya said the case has been handed over to the police in Moinabad for further investigation.

LDF steals a march on UDF with Kerala candidate list

Ruling front workers kick off roadshows after CPI(M). CPI name 106 candidates in back-to-back press conferences; Congress and IUML hold meeting to finalise the UDF's seat-sharing formula

The Hindu Bureau
THIRUVANANTHAPURAM

The Left Democratic Front (LDF) sought to steal a march on the Congress-led United Democratic Front (UDF), with its two major alliance partners, the Communist Party of India (CPI) and the CPI (Marxist), announcing their candidates within an hour of the Election Commission (EC) announcing April 9 as the date for the Assembly election in Kerala.

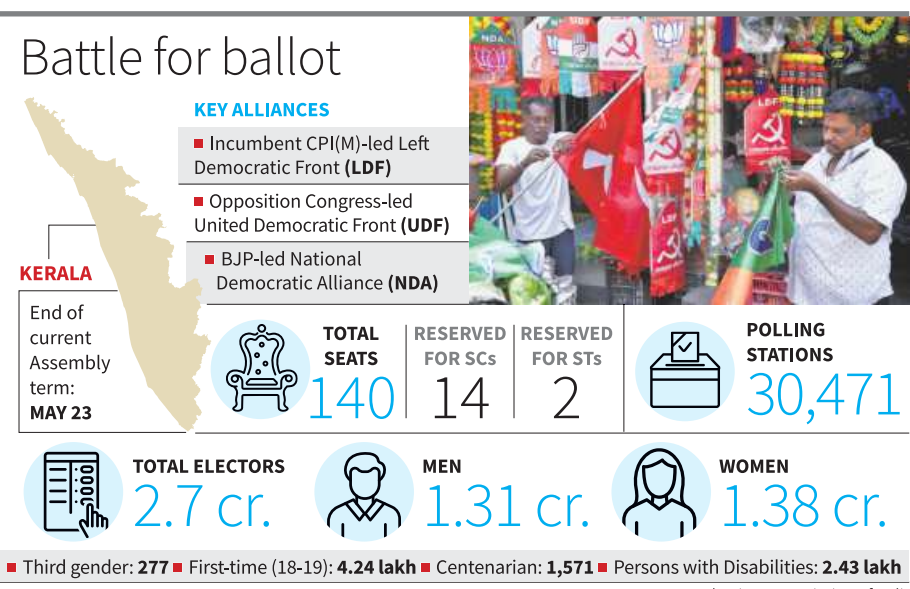
The back-to-back press conferences by CPI(M) State secretary M.V. Govindan and CPI State secretary Binoy Viswam seemed a televised cue for scores of LDF workers organising roadshows with ruling front candidates in tow.

Key names

Mr. Govindan announced candidates for 81 seats. Among them are six CPI (M)-backed LDF candidates contesting as Independents, including in Palakkad.

The other 75 candidates will contest on party ticket, including Chief Minister Pinarayi Vijayan, LDF convener T.P. Ramakrishnan, and Cabinet Ministers in the State government. P.K. Shyamala, All India Democratic Women's Association (AIDWA) leader, will contest from Thaliparambu in Kannur.

Of the 81 candidates, 56 are incumbents, including former Devaswom Board



The Assembly election for 140 seats in the State will be held on April 9, with counting on May 4

Minister Kadakampally Surendran.

Speaker A.N. Shamshere, CPI(M) State Secretary member M. Swaraj, and Mr. Govindan are not in the fray.

Mr. Viswam said the CPI would field 25 candidates, including an Independent. Four Ministers will contest, including K. Rajan, G.R. Anil, J. Chinchurani, and P. Prasad.

The CPI decided to put up a strong fight against the Leader of the Opposition, V.D. Satheesan, in his home turf in Paravoor by fielding the incumbent MLA for Kaipamangalam,

E.T. Taison. Mr. Govindan said other LDF partners, including the Kerala Congress (M), would also announce their candidates soon.

Scramble in Congress

Faced with the threat of being outpaced by the LDF in the poll campaign, the Congress-led UDF appeared to scramble to finalise seat-sharing in its own coalition on Sunday, with Mr. Satheesan and senior Congress leader Ramesh Chennithala holding a closed-door meeting with the Indian Union Muslim League (IUML) leadership at Aluva Palace in Ernakulam.

The meeting gained importance against the backdrop of reports that the IUML has demanded a higher number of seats, including a few in central

Kerala, in a bid to expand the party's political base and also demonstrate its heft in the UDF.

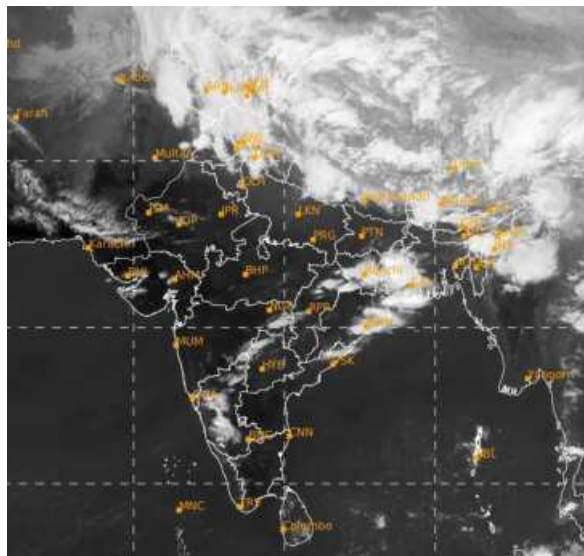
Moreover, the IUML is reportedly weighing whether to swap seats with the Congress in the Thiruvambadi, Pattambi, Kongadu, and Kalamassery constituencies.

Congress insiders said former State Congress chief and Lok Sabha member K. Sudhakaran's assertion that he would contest the Assembly election from Kannur has caused a hiccup in finalising party candidates before the AICC's Central Election Committee headed by Madhusoodhanan Mistry meets next week.

The party has also faced difficulties in choosing Assembly hopefuls, as several leaders are jockeying for seats.

WEATHERWATCH

Rainfall, temperature & air quality in select metros yesterday



TEMPERATURE DATA: IMD, POLLUTION DATA: CPCB, MAP: INSAT/IMD (TAKEN AT 17.00 HRS)

Forecast for Monday: Heavy rainfall very likely at isolated places over Arunachal Pradesh, Assam and Meghalaya. Thunderstorm accompanied with hailstorm likely at isolated places over Bihar, East Uttar Pradesh, Gangetic West Bengal, Jharkhand, Odisha and Uttarakhand.

CITY	RAIN	MAX	MIN	CITY	RAIN	MAX	MIN
Agartala	0.3	31.7	21.4	Kozhikode	—	35.4	27.0
Ahmedabad	—	38.4	23.4	Kurnool	—	38.3	24.7
Aizawl	—	30.0	13.8	Lucknow	—	31.6	20.6
Allahabad	—	35.6	19.0	Madurai	—	38.2	24.3
Bengaluru	—	35.5	00.0	Mangaluru	—	33.4	25.4
Bhopal	—	36.4	18.6	Mumbai	—	33.2	24.0
Bhubaneswar	—	32.2	25.5	Mysuru	—	34.0	19.0
Chandigarh	—	26.5	14.8	New Delhi	0.8	28.4	18.3
Chennai	—	31.6	23.9	Patna	—	33.0	22.3
Coimbatore	—	35.4	22.4	Port Blair	—	31.4	26.8
Dehradun	—	28.5	16.8	Puducherry	—	31.8	22.2
Gangtok	0.4	16.7	11.5	Pune	—	38.2	23.1
Goa	—	33.2	26.0	Raipur	—	37.1	22.2
Guwahati	1.0	24.5	19.0	Ranchi	—	35.5	18.0
Hubballi	—	36.0	18.0	Shillong	8.0	21.6	12.5
Hyderabad	—	38.6	22.0	Shimla	—	20.0	12.0
Imphal	5.4	20.7	14.0	Srinagar	—	11.5	9.4
Jaipur	—	35.7	22.7	Thiruvananthapuram	—	34.3	23.8
Kochi	—	32.4	25.8	Tiruchi	—	36.3	24.4
Kohima	—	—	—	Vijayawada	—	35.3	23.4
Kolkata	—	30.6	25.6	Visakhapatnam	—	31.6	24.5

(Rainfall data in mm; temperature in Celsius)

Pollutants in the air you are breathing

CITIES	SO ₂	NO ₂	CO	PM2.5	PM10	CODE	Yesterday
Ahmedabad	.85	.80	64	135	209	—	In observation made at 4.00 p.m., Korba,
Bengaluru	.4	.18	38	171	154	—	Chhattisgarh, recorded an
Chennai	.6	.4	40	30	68	—	overall air quality index
Delhi	.17	110	25	178	268	—	(AQI) score of 305
Hyderabad	.16	.15	38	64	93	—	indicating an unhealthy
Kolkata	.6	.36	28	55	64	—	level of pollution. In
Lucknow	.9	.22	58	193	148	—	contrast, Naharlagun,
Mumbai	.1	.24	46	118	—	—	Arunachal Pradesh
Pune	.1	.36	24	100	118	—	recorded a healthy AQI
Visakhapatnam	.33	.46	15	44	108	—	score of 18.

Air Quality Code: ■ Poor ■ Moderate ■ Good (Readings indicate average AQI)

SO₂: Sulphur Dioxide. Short-term exposure can harm the respiratory system, making breathing difficult. It can affect visibility by reacting with other air particles to form haze and stain culturally important objects such as statues and monuments.

NO₂: Nitrogen Dioxide. Aggravates respiratory illness, causes haze to form by reacting with other air particles, causes acid rain, pollutes coastal waters.

CO: Carbon monoxide. High concentration in air reduces oxygen supply to critical organs like the heart and brain. At very high levels, it can cause dizziness, confusion, unconsciousness and even death.

PM2.5 & PM10: Particulate matter pollution can cause irritation of the eyes, nose and throat, coughing, chest tightness and shortness of breath, reduced lung function, irregular heartbeat, asthma attacks, heart attacks and premature death in people with heart or lung disease

Congress, BJP gear up for major face-off in Karnataka bypolls

The Hindu Bureau
BENGALURU

The announcement of by-elections to the Davangere South and Bagalkot Assembly seats in Karnataka on April 9, both won by the ruling Congress last time, is set to ignite an intense fight between the Congress and the BJP. The counting of votes will take place on May 4.

The by-election follows

the death of two former Ministers, Shamanur Shivashankarappa and H.Y. Meti.

For the Congress, the by-election comes at a time when the party is gripped by leadership tussle between Chief Minister Siddaramaiah and Deputy Chief Minister D.K. Shivakumar.

Meanwhile, the BJP has begun poll preparations by appointing in-charge leaders for both seats.

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This is applicable to all Open (Domestic / Global) Tenders issued through e-procurement portal of CIL.

This information is also available on BCCL Website www.bcclweb.in

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PERSONAL

CHANGE OF NAME

I, **KORSAPAATI** Venkata Sai Bharadwaja (Old Name), s/o Late Korsapaati Manoj Kumar, r/o Villa No. 30, Phase II, Srinivasa Brundavanam Gated Community, Padugupadu (V), Kovur (M), SP5R Nellore Dist. AP-524137, here by declare that I have changed my name as Venkat Bharadwaj (New Name) for all further purpose.

I, **S** Lakshmi Sinthiya, wife of Suriya Narayanan M, born on 26th August 1982 (District of Birth: Virudhunagar), residing at No. 81, T2, Park Vista II, New Kumaran Nagar 3rd Main Street, Sholinganallur, Chennai-600 119, shall henceforth be known as Lakshmi Sinthiya M

I, **SELVANKAR** Selvankar S/o Mahadevan 62yrs resi: 129, I Sector 6th St, KK Nagar, Chennai-78 shall henceforth be known as Selvankar Mahadevan

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MUSIC DANCE DRAMA

Rasika Ranjani Sabha Foundation, Ch-4
Today at 06.30 p.m. Nama Sankirtanam by Kalakkad Shri Venkatachalam. Ph. No.: 8610357987. Rasika's welcome.

Sri Thyaga Brahma Gana Sabha (Regd) Vanimahala, Ph: 28152166
In association with Sri Kanchi Mahaswami Vidya Mandir Rajakilpakkam, Chennai, Integrated Enterprises (India) Ltd. and City Union Bank celebrates 18TH NAMASANKERTHANA VAIBHAVAM 2026 at Vani Mahala. Today 4.30 pm Ashtapathi (19-24) by Smt. Gayathri Magesh Bhagavathasri and Party. 6.30 pm Abhang Divyvananamam by Kadayanallur Sri Rajagopala Das Bhagavathar and Party. All are welcome.

MISCELLANEOUS

Narada Gana Sabha Trust, Ph: 24993201
Today Main Hall (Sathguru Gnanananda Hall - 16th to 18th Daily at 6.30 pm - Sri R. Krishnaswami Memorial Lecture - "Namasankeerthan Mummoothigal - Sri Bodhendra Saraswati Swamigal" - Satsang by H.H. Maharanyam Sri Sri Muralidhara Swamiji. All are welcome.

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House decorum

The ruling party and the Opposition must rise above partisanship

The Lok Sabha rejected by voice vote, on March 11, a resolution under Article 94(C) of the Constitution for the removal of Lok Sabha Speaker Om Birla from office, but only after a hostile debate on the functioning of the House deepened the wedge between the government and the Opposition. In principle, Parliament is the foundation of representative democracy, and its routine functions act as an instrument that holds the cabinet accountable. As a forum for government-Opposition interaction, it is meant to operate in a structured, methodical way. Single-party dominance has eroded all these formal and informal functions of legislatures at all levels, and the Lok Sabha, sadly, has become a platform for political partisanship. In recent years, the chairs of the Lok Sabha and the Rajya Sabha have been dragged into political conflict. In 2024, there was an Opposition resolution to remove Jagdeep Dhankhar as Rajya Sabha Chairman. Though the resolution did not pass, he resigned as Vice-President for unexplained reasons. The Opposition has raised concerns over the Lok Sabha's functioning, but what precipitated their protest into a formal resolution for Mr. Birla's removal was, possibly, his statement that he had confidential knowledge that Congress women MPs might act against Prime Minister Narendra Modi on the House floor.

Opposition MPs are routinely denied the opportunity to raise substantive issues, though the government cites statistics in its rebuttal. The Speaker had disallowed Leader of the Opposition (Lok Sabha) Rahul Gandhi from quoting former Army Chief M.M. Naravane's unpublished memoir, which discusses Prime Minister Narendra Modi's role in the 2020 military standoff with China. The microphones of Opposition MPs are frequently switched off during debates. The Opposition has pointed out that in February, Mr. Gandhi was interrupted 20 times while speaking during the Motion of Thanks to the President's Address and also blocked from raising the Gautam Adani investigation issue in the U.S. and the EU-U.S. trade deal. The government argued that the Opposition was given 56% of Zero Hour time, and that NDA MPs, despite their majority, received 321 supplementary questions against the Opposition's 364 during his tenure. Home Minister Amit Shah said that the House's productivity during Mr. Birla's tenure had been high and that it had debated in 14 regional languages. Mr. Shah also cornered Mr. Gandhi for being frequently absent from the House. The resolution and the debate manifested a deeply fractured polity in need of urgent corrective measures. The ruling majority and the Opposition must rise above partisanship and restore the majesty of Parliament.

Another barrier

Mandatory period leave sans parity in recruitment will hurt women

When considering a measure to address a work-related need, care must be taken to ensure that it does not inadvertently reduce the employee's opportunity to work. This was again made evident on March 13, when a two-judge Bench of the Supreme Court, headed by Chief Justice of India Surya Kant, refused to entertain a petition seeking a law providing menstrual leave for women workers and students. The Court cautioned that mandatory menstrual leave could unintentionally hinder women's careers and deny them "big responsibilities". Instead, it encouraged "voluntary" initiatives by States. In Odisha, women government employees up to the age of 55 can take an additional day of leave each month, while Kerala grants menstrual leave to female trainees in ITIs and universities. Karnataka issued an order that entitles women in the public and private sectors up to the age of 52 to a day's menstrual leave a month, raising concerns whether private establishments might be disincentivised from hiring women. This government order has been challenged in the High Court. Such changes must come with safeguards, and the top court rightly suggested that the government come up with a menstrual leave policy in consultation with stakeholders – as it had done in 2024 as well.

Many women face debilitating menstrual pain and conditions such as endometriosis, PCOD and PCOS. But the Court's reasoning rests on another, more universal reality: women are already disadvantaged at work, facing systemic barriers such as unequal pay. In this context, mandatory menstrual leave could become a form of biological determinism, limiting opportunities, pay and promotions for women. In countries where menstrual leave policies exist, they are either poorly enforced or are not opted for by most women. In Spain, legislation enacted in 2023, and hailed as "... historic ... for feminist progress", saw few women exercising the right a year later. In Zambia, some women said it was being misused. In India, the female Labour Force Participation Rate rose from 23.3% in 2017-18 to 41.7% in 2023-24, driven largely by rural women entering work due to distress, insecure employment and unpaid household work. In this context, a blanket menstrual leave policy could be counterproductive: many women cannot afford to lose work-days, and in informal jobs, it may also be unenforceable. Providing free sanitary products and medicines at workplaces and allowing time off under existing leave provisions would be a way forward. That would be an acknowledgement of biological realities without turning such well-intentioned but poorly thought-out initiatives into yet another barrier to women's participation.

In the aftermath of the war in West Asia, crude oil prices surged to as high as \$118 a barrel last week. Alongside rising tensions, this situation has been building for over two months. Since mid-December 2025, when Brent crude stood at \$57.56, prices have surged by more than 100%. They have, however, come down since then but remain in three digits, with no immediate sign of easing.

Historically, geopolitical shocks follow a predictable pattern. There is an immediate market overreaction that is followed by gradual stabilisation as trade routes adjust. However, the global oil market is once again operating under a profound geopolitical shadow.

What has changed in the development now The developments in West Asia, intensifying strategic rivalries among major powers, and persistent conflict-driven uncertainty have brought geopolitics back to the centre of the energy discourse. Yet, the nature of this influence has shifted. Unlike previously, where regional conflicts rarely removed Gulf barrels from the global pool, the current disruptions have created tangible barriers to supply, fundamentally altering the costs, confidence, and conditions of the oil trade.

For major importing economies such as India, this shift has significant implications. Oil security is no longer just about physical access. It is also defined by exposure to the financial, logistical, and political uncertainties surrounding every shipment.

The vulnerability of global maritime arteries is stark. Around a fifth of global oil consumption is transported through the Strait of Hormuz, and roughly a tenth of seaborne crude passes through the Bab el-Mandeb and Suez corridor. The ongoing conflict involving Israel and Iran has effectively sidelined 20% of global supplies, even in the absence of planned production cuts. The market has reacted sharply to these signals. Over the past year, Brent crude has frequently fluctuated by 5%-10% within days of military or diplomatic developments, regardless of actual production volumes. Currently, however, the impact on physical supply is so drastic that prices continue to climb without a visible peak.

Tensions do more than just inflate the price of a barrel. They make maritime insecure. Chokepoints remain vital arteries of trade, but their significance today lies in making global machinery vulnerable. Even limited disruptions or attacks on commercial shipping can alter vessel routing and raise freight costs. These drive up freight rates; the world has seen daily rates for supertankers more than double), affect shipping



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As tensions rise and oil volatility grows, importing nations will need adaptable energy and trade strategies

insurance premiums, and tighten vessel availability. Major container carriers have implemented emergency conflict surcharges or war risk surcharges. These escalations ripple through the supply chain, directly influencing landed import prices.

It is about politics Furthermore, oil has been transformed from a mere commodity into a political instrument. The redirection of Russian crude following the Ukraine conflict illustrates this dynamic. Although Russia maintained export volumes by pivoting to Asian markets, the shift introduced longer shipping routes, complex payment arrangements, and evolving compliance frameworks. What appeared stable in volume was highly volatile in operational and financial terms.

For importing countries, this creates a dual exposure. Price volatility is no longer driven solely by the supply-demand balance but by changes in geopolitical sentiment. Markets respond to diplomatic signals, military developments and regulatory announcements with a speed that often exceeds the pace of actual trade flows. This weakens the historical relationship between production levels and consumer prices.

The growing role of financial markets amplifies geopolitical sentiment, as oil is traded not only as a physical commodity but also as a financial asset through futures, options, and derivatives. During periods of stress, investors use oil as both an inflation hedge and a risk-sensitive instrument. This explains why speculative positions often expand even when physical inventories are comfortable – prices reflect expectations and portfolio behaviour rather than immediate scarcity.

Strategic Petroleum Reserves (SPRs) have also evolved. Originally intended to address physical supply interruptions, they are now deployed to counter psychological volatility in the market. For instance, G-7 leaders have announced the release of 400 million barrels of oil in response to the war in West Asia (which is said to be about 20 days of the usual oil traffic through the Strait of Hormuz). The goal is to stabilise market sentiment as much as it is to provide physical barrels. The news of these discussions recently prompted a sell-off, easing Brent and West Texas Intermediate gains to some extent.

Major powers shape this environment in different ways. The United States, now one of the world's largest producers of various petroleum products, influences markets through its strategic stock policies and diplomatic engagement with producers.

Meanwhile, Asia has become the primary centre of demand growth, accounting for the majority of incremental oil consumption over the past decade. Producer coordination through organisations such as the Organization of the Petroleum Exporting Countries continues to influence supply management, but its impact now interacts with geopolitical risk premia embedded in prices.

The continuing relevance of oil The energy transition adds another layer of complexity. While renewable energy and electric mobility are expanding, oil remains central to the transport, aviation and petrochemicals sectors/industries. Global oil demand still exceeds 105 million barrels per day, and petrochemicals account for a rising share of incremental consumption. This produces a segmented market: one part linked to declining fuel use, another tied to industrial growth. Thus, geopolitics continues to exert influence over a commodity whose strategic relevance is changing but not disappearing.

For India, where oil demand is not expected to peak soon and is projected to drive much of global growth, this environment highlights the need for adaptability rather than alarm. The ability to process diverse crude grades, source from multiple geographies and maintain strategic reserves provides buffers against instability. Equally crucial is building commercial and financial expertise to navigate complex trading arrangements. Energy policy, in this sense, must integrate diplomacy, maritime awareness and market analytics.

This evolving structure complicates the notion of energy security. It now requires resilience not only against supply disruptions but also against financial and logistical shocks. Payment systems, shipping insurance, and contract enforcement have become integral to the energy security architecture.

The broader lesson is that oil has entered a phase where risk is as significant as the resource itself. Geopolitics will continue to influence oil prices by shaping perceptions of safety, reliability, and continuity, as well as affecting the physical flow of oil. Understanding this transformation is essential for managing a vulnerable world. Stability now depends on preserving predictable trade mechanisms and avoiding diplomatic ruptures that amplify uncertainty. In the years ahead, the resilience of importing nations will depend both on the origin of their crude and on how effectively they manage the political and financial currents surrounding every barrel of oil.

Building India's climate resilience with water at the core

Branded the "COP of Implementation," COP 30, the 30th session of the United Nations Climate Change Conference, held in Belém, Brazil, in November 2025, marked a decisive shift in how adaptation is understood – not as an abstract promise of resilience, but as a measurable, accountable discipline grounded in systems that function under stress. At the centre of this shift is 'water', moving from the margins of infrastructure planning to the core of climate survival. For the first time, global adaptation indicators integrated water, sanitation, and hygiene (WASH) into climate accountability, reshaping the water-food-climate nexus with implications for all countries, including India.

Climate change felt through water Climate change is experienced most viscerally through water. Floods submerge cities, droughts hollow out rural economies, glacial melt destabilises Himalayan river systems, saline intrusion contaminates coastal aquifers, and erratic monsoons disrupt food security. Agriculture alone accounts for roughly 40% of anthropogenic methane emissions, with rice cultivation, livestock systems, and organic waste at the centre of the challenge. So, water use efficiency, wastewater reuse, aquifer recharge, and resilient sanitation systems are now climate strategies as much as development priorities.

The 59 Belém Adaptation Indicators, under the UAE Framework for Global Climate Resilience, signal a new discipline in global governance. Two clusters stand out. The first focuses on climate-resilient water and sanitation systems: reducing climate-induced water scarcity, building resilience to floods and droughts, ensuring universal access to safe drinking water, and upgrading sanitation infrastructure to withstand extreme events. The second emphasises risk governance: universal multi-hazard early warning systems by 2027, strengthened hydrometeorological services, and updated national vulnerability assessments by 2030. Water security is no longer about asset creation; it



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Guided by the Belém indicators, India can set an example for the Global South by making water systems resilient

is about whether systems continue to deliver when climate stress intensifies.

Not starting from scratch India is building on existing foundations. The consolidation, in 2019, of water governance under the Ministry of Jal Shakti marked a shift toward integrated stewardship, while the Water Vision 2047 aligns with Belém's adaptation framework, emphasising sustainability, equity, and resilience.

Groundwater management illustrates this transition. The evolution of the National Aquifer Mapping and Management (NAQUIM) Programme 2.0 has moved from mapping aquifers to implementing aquifer-level management plans (hydrogeological knowledge to policy action), hydrologising the systems integration that global adaptation indicators now require.

River rejuvenation tells a similar story. The National Mission for Clean Ganga (NMCG) has moved beyond sewage treatment to integrate biodiversity, digital monitoring, and international collaboration, making clean rivers a buffer against climate volatility.

Despite visible progress, three systemic risks threaten to slow momentum. First, water scarcity remains acute and unevenly distributed. Most climate disasters in India are water-related, and WASH systems often serve as the first line of defence. Ensuring rural and urban water supply during floods or prolonged droughts would require climate stress testing of infrastructure, diversification of sources, and redundancy in service delivery – not simply expanding coverage figures.

Second, adaptation finance remains fragile. While global rhetoric speaks of mobilising \$1.3 trillion annually by 2035, operational pathways remain uncertain. Without predictable and accessible flows of adaptation finance, post-disaster recovery will crowd out long-term resilience planning. Water projects need explicit classification and funding as climate investments, not mere sectoral costs.

Third, digital fragmentation persists. Despite India's vast hydrological and meteorological data, an Artificial Intelligence-driven real-time integration into planning, budgeting, and local governance systems remains limited.

A closer look at India's institutional landscape reveals that most global adaptation targets already have corresponding domestic missions. Drinking water coverage, sanitation expansion, irrigation efficiency, urban water reforms, and climate action plans exist across Ministries and States. Climate stress indicators must be embedded into mission dashboards.

Belém calls for convergence, not reinvention. India's strength in digital public infrastructure offers an opportunity to integrate hydrological data, crop advisories, insurance and financial flows into interoperable platforms for real-time decision-making.

Belém indicators guide climate survival The Belém indicators are not a bureaucratic checklist; they are a dashboard for survival. If implemented with seriousness, they can transform adaptation from a peripheral conversation into the organising principle of development strategy. India stands at a pivotal moment. Its domestic water reforms, technological capabilities, and community-led initiatives position it not just as a participant in global climate negotiations but also as a potential leader in operationalising adaptation at scale.

Water must anchor climate action. Implementation must be swift, equitable, and technologically robust. Resilience should be measured not by infrastructure built, but by systems that continue to serve people when the next flood arrives, when the next drought lingers, and when the next climate shock tests the nation's preparedness. India has much of the blueprint in place. India should align its missions, metrics and money quickly enough to convert ambition into measurable resilience – and in doing so, lead the Global South by its exemplary performance.

LETTERS TO THE EDITOR

Poll bugle sounded

The announcement of the election dates for Assembly polls in West Bengal, Kerala/Keralam, Tamil Nadu, Assam and Puducherry, marks a key moment for democracy. It is important that these elections are conducted in a peaceful, transparent and fair manner so that every citizen can cast their vote without fear or pressure. The role of the Election

Commission of India becomes extremely crucial in maintaining fairness and ensuring that all rules and regulations are properly followed. At the same time, political parties should focus on healthy debates, development issues and constructive policies instead of spreading hatred, misinformation or creating unnecessary conflict during their election campaigning. Responsible campaigning

will help voters make better decisions and strengthen democratic values.

Aarchi Verma,
Rajpura, Punjab

Institutions, scrutiny

Our democracy confronts an unusual moment: challenges to two of its most consequential constitutional offices — the Speaker of the Lok Sabha and the Chief Election Commissioner — that

prompts a reflection on the resilience and the vulnerabilities of our institutional design. Perhaps the very emergence of such challenges would testify to the robustness of democratic culture, when institutions are openly scrutinised and when public debate engages even the highest offices. That said, the frequency and intensity of such confrontations risk

signalling a gradual erosion of trust in institutions that depend heavily on perceived and demonstrable neutrality. A question follows. Which lapse would inflict the greater injury on democracy — an election widely doubted for its fairness, or a legislature whose procedural guardrails weaken? Either scenario chips away at public confidence, though

electoral credibility arguably forms the foundational pillar of the democratic order. The test for any democracy is not the absence of institutional strain but its capacity to confront such stress without corroding the public faith that sustains it.

R. Narayanan,
Navi Mumbai

Letters emailed to letters@thehindu.co.in must carry the postal address.

On the right to die with dignity

On an evening in 2013, 20-year-old Harish Rana fell from the fourth floor of his PG accommodation and sustained critical injuries. His condition confined him to a bed while tubes kept him on life support. Owing to his Persistent Vegetative State (PVS), he responded to no stimuli around him and was largely nursed by his parents, with frequent visits to the hospital. Mr. Rana's closest friends and family, who fondly describe him as energetic and exuberant, were faced with the agonising pain of witnessing his stasis. His parents, along with the doctors, devoted 13 years in tending to Mr. Rana, but no improvement was seen. Confronted with such despairing circumstances, the parents moved the Supreme Court to withdraw life support, so that nature can be allowed to take its course. What followed was a pivotal discourse on the import of life under Article 21 of our Constitution.

A respectable death
The Constitution's tryst with 'Right to Life with dignity' was first laid down in *Gian Kaur vs State of Punjab* (1996) where the Supreme Court held that 'life' under Article 21 included the right to live with dignity. However, in *Gian Kaur*, the Court opined that Article 21 did not include the right to die. Fifteen years later, a similar case reached the Supreme Court when a young Aruna Shanbaug, owing to a brutal sexual assault, was left in PVS. Pinki Virani, journalist, and human-rights activist, petitioned the Supreme Court as Aruna's friend for withdrawal of her life support. Although under its own circumstances, Virani's plea was rejected, it culminated in the crucial decision of *Aruna R. Shanbaug vs Union of India* (2011). The Supreme Court drew sustenance from foreign legal frameworks and recognised passive euthanasia in cases of patients with terminal illness and undergoing prolonged, but



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The right of refusal of medical treatment was held to be a manifestation of dignity intersecting with privacy, autonomy, and self-determination

ineffective treatment. Guidelines were framed to bridge the legislative gap, until Parliament promulgated on the subject. Additionally, the Law Commission in 2006 and 2012, entered into an in-depth examination of the above-detailed issues and made extensive observations. It reported that withholding life support from terminally ill patients should not attract criminal liability if done in pursuance of the "best interest of the patient."

The watershed moment on the subject was the 2018 Constitution Bench's decision in *Common Cause vs Union of India*. Armed with developing jurisprudence on the subject, the Supreme Court unequivocally recognised and permitted the withdrawal/ withholding of medical treatment to fall within Article 21. The right of refusal of medical treatment was held to be a manifestation of dignity intersecting with privacy, autonomy, and self-determination. This judgment provided extensive guidelines and underwent certain modifications in a similarly titled 2023 decision. These are now cumulatively referred to as the 'Common Cause guidelines', which rest on two core principles: first, that the intervention in question must qualify as "medical treatment"; and second, that its withdrawal must be strictly in the patient's "best interest."

The Supreme Court embedded various safeguards to prevent misuse and a detailed procedure involving opinions of primary and secondary Medical Boards prior to undertaking such decisions. The legislative void was once again highlighted by the Court and one Judge expressed the "pious hope" for legislative intervention. This hope still lingers.

Case evaluation
The Harish Rana chronicle has now reached its end with the intervention by the Supreme Court. Speaking through two judges, who authored separate but concurring judgments, the Court allowed the withdrawal of life

support from Mr. Rana under the Common Cause guidelines. Since he relied on Clinically Assisted Nutrition and Hydration (CANH), the first question which required consideration was whether CANH qualified as 'medical treatment.' To answer this, the Court noted that the administration of CANH requires careful and experienced medical supervision. Since such skills are only available by drawing upon medical knowledge, and owing to its continuous periodic evaluation, emergency medical management and supervision, it was held to be 'medical treatment.' The second question was whether the withdrawal of CANH from Mr. Rana was in his best interests. It held that 'best interests' must be envisaged from the lens of the stakeholders, who are the next of kin and medical boards. It was rightly opined that a doctor's duty to perform treatment continues till it is capable of "conferring some therapeutic benefit." When recovery is impossible, the continuation of treatment merely prolongs biological existence de-hors any benefits. It led to the sole conclusion – withdrawal of treatment which was noted to be in Mr. Rana's best interests.

A definitive end
"For in that sleep of death what dreams may come, when we have shuffled off this mortal coil, must give us pause." Through his prose, the Bard cautioned that hesitation about death stems from the uncertainty of what comes after. However, what is definitive is that the ones who pass-on tend to live through us. Harish Rana will soon die. Yet, his contributions will forever be etched in history and in our constitutional jurisprudence. And so, the advancement of constitutional morality is not only circumscribed to legislative actions which reach the country at large. It is also through addressing uncomfortable issues that advance the cause for humanity, even if they concern just an indiscernible minority.

Credit wars escalate as polls approach

Two parallel road inaugurations lay bare Kerala's friction with the Centre

STATE OF PLAY
Tiki Rajwi
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A 'boycott row' by Kerala's Left Democratic Front (LDF) government overshadowed Prime Minister Narendra Modi's visit to the poll-bound southern State this month. For the political pundit and the general observer alike, it marked the latest episode among the long-running confrontations between Kerala Chief Minister Pinarayi Vijayan and the Bharatiya Janata Party (BJP)-led Union government over Centre-State relations and fiscal federalism.

The Communist Party of India (Marxist) (CPI(M)) and the LDF sought to depict the exclusion of Kerala Public Works Minister Mohammed Riyas from the inauguration ceremony of two National Highways (NH) reaches as yet another attempt by the BJP to monopolise the spotlight and claim credit for development projects in the run-up to the Assembly elections. The Prime Minister was in Kochi on March 11 to inaugurate a clutch of high-profile projects, which included the two stretches of NH-66, the main north-south artery.

Miffed over the fact that Mr. Riyas was not invited, Chief Minister Pinarayi Vijayan and the Ministers for Local Self Government and Electricity, M.B. Rajesh and K. Krishnakutty respectively, also gave the event a miss. In battle-mode, the CPI(M) organised a parallel inauguration of the two highway stretches – Thalappady-Chengala and Vengalam-Ramanattukara – with Mr. Riyas taking centre-stage. A furious Mr. Riyas pointed out that while he, the State's

Public Works Minister, was kept out, the Union government had thought it fit to extend an invitation to Rajeev Chandrasekhar, the State president of the BJP.

Mr. Riyas and the CPI(M) stated that had it not been for the LDF government, NH development in Kerala would have been a distant dream.

Price for a road
At the core of the State government's grievance lies the fact that Kerala, in an unprecedented step, had decided to bear 25% of the land acquisition cost for the widening of the NH. According to the LDF government, the National Highway Authority of India (NHAI) had withdrawn from the project in 2014, citing a delay in the acquisition of the necessary land. The project was revived after the first LDF government led by Mr. Vijayan, which came to power in 2016, agreed to bear 25% of the land acquisition cost. Kerala had paid ₹5,580.74 crore, making it the first State to do so. Kerala had sourced the amount through the Kerala Infrastructure Investment Fund Board (KIIFB), a special purpose vehicle that mobilises resources for large infrastructure projects. Mr. Riyas also recalled instances where the Union Minister for Road Transport and Highways Nitin Gadkari had praised Mr. Vijayan's government for having sped up the acquisition of land. Interest-

ingly, Mr. Gadkari was also absent from the event.

Road development has been a perennially contentious issue in Kerala given its large population, geographical peculiarities and high demand for land. To be fair, the higher compensation payouts enabled by the Centre's Right to Fair Compensation and Transparency in Land Acquisition, Rehabilitation and Resettlement Act, 2013, has also had a hand in the revival of NH development in Kerala.

The debt problem
Beyond the political sabre-rattling, the latest row spun the spotlight back on a related issue: Kerala's objections against the restrictions imposed by the Union government on its borrowing ability, citing off-budget borrowings by the KIIFB and the Kerala Social Security Pension Ltd. The State has repeatedly urged the Centre to expand its borrowing space by a sum equivalent to its NH spending. It was not that long ago when NH development was caught in the midst of a Centre-State blame-game in Kerala after parts of the newly-constructed highway collapsed, raising questions about quality. Also, this is not the first time where 'credit' for large undertakings or schemes has become a bone of contention. For instance, the Centre's insistence that houses constructed under Kerala's LIFE Mission housing project must display the Pradhan Mantri Awas Yojana logo had drawn sharp responses from Mr. Vijayan's government. It is to be expected that 'credit wars' would again take centre-stage with Kerala moving into election mode. But while governments come and go, all that matters, ultimately, is whether taxpayers' money is being spent wisely.

Trump's tenure sees highest external attacks in a decade

Contrary to President Donald Trump's promises, U.S. interventions resulted in at least a thousand fatalities in 2025

DATA POINT
Nitika Francis
Sambavi Parthasarathy

When U.S. President Donald Trump came into power for the second time in January last year, he claimed that his proudest legacy would be that of a "peacemaker and unifier". In the initial months after his inauguration, Mr. Trump also openly lobbied for winning the Nobel Peace Prize. Yet, contrary to his words, the legacy of Mr. Trump during his second tenure has seen an explosion in hostile actions, euphemistically termed 'coercive diplomacy', the 'Donroe Doctrine' etc. besides military operations that have exacerbated conflicts across the world.

Increase in attacks
In fact, data maintained by the Armed Conflict Location and Event Data Project (ACLED) show that Mr. Trump's second tenure has seen the highest number of external interventions by the U.S. forces and resultant casualties in the last 15 years. An analysis of external interventions by the U.S. shows that the first year of Mr. Trump's second term saw at least 663 military intervention events (air strikes, attacks, disruptions by weapons use) in other sovereign nations. In 2025 alone, the U.S.'s external attacks surged by almost 50% compared to 2024.

This is even higher than the number of such interventions recorded during his first presidential term between 2017 and 2021. While the final year of the Joe Biden administration also saw a high number of such interventions with 453 events, the numbers surged further under Mr. Trump, in stark contrast to his promises of ending foreign wars (**Chart 1**).

Data show that between 2011 and 2014, the highest share of U.S. involvement was seen in South Asia, specifically in Pakistan. Ho-

wever, in the last five years, the U.S.'s involvement increased dramatically in West Asia and eastern Africa, specifically in Yemen and Somalia (**Chart 2**). Yemen accounted for almost 60% of the U.S.'s external attacks in the last 10 years, resulting in more than 1,400 fatalities. While the U.S. began its attacks on Yemen in 2002, following the 9/11 attacks, the interventions increased after the collapse of the Yemeni government in early 2015.

In 2025, President Donald Trump initiated significant military strikes on the Houthis, marking the largest U.S. operation in the region since he took office. The U.S. vowed to continue these attacks as long as the Houthis conducted attacks on shipping lanes in the Red Sea.

The situation was more dire in Somalia, which accounted for close to 30% of the U.S.'s external attacks. Since 2015, the U.S.'s engagements have resulted in more than 4,000 fatalities.

In 2020, at the time of his first administration, Mr. Trump had ordered the Pentagon to withdraw most U.S. troops from Somalia, where they were deployed in an extended fight against the al-Shabab, an al-Qaeda affiliate. Mr. Biden, who took office after Mr. Trump, reversed this order in 2022. However, the current administration under Mr. Trump has not shown any indication of reverting to the earlier Trump order. The U.S. forces have engaged in more than 150 attacks in Somalia since 2025, almost half the total number of attacks carried out during Mr. Trump's entire first term.

In his inaugural speech last year, Mr. Trump said, "We will measure our success not only by the battles we win but also by the wars that we end and perhaps most importantly, the wars we never get into."

Bloody regime
Mr. Trump has only contradicted himself by getting the U.S. involved

in Israel's wars on Iran. Even Mr. Trump is unsure of how these hostilities will end.

An analysis by the Centre for Strategic and International Studies pointed out that though the recent U.S. military presence in West Asia is at its highest level since the 2003 invasion of Iraq, it is inadequate in the size and capabilities required for major combat or regime change. Last August, claiming credit for settling the India-Pakistan tensions, Mr. Trump said, "I love saving lives...And you know, when you save lives, you really end up having a peaceful world."

Data contradict this too. Mr. Trump's first year of his second term has left the country with more blood on its hands than any other President's term in the past 15 years.

Last year was the most severe in terms of fatalities, with at least a thousand people being killed by U.S.-led forces (**Chart 3**). This is significantly higher than the death toll due to interventions in each of the preceding four years. The U.S.'s joint attacks with Israel too have come at a severe human cost with reports stating thousands of casualties.

Domestic sensibilities
Mr. Trump's idea of peace is unpopular even among Americans. A *Reuters* poll found that more than 40% of Americans disapproved of Mr. Trump's attack on Iran.

A similar sentiment was observed earlier this year when American forces invaded Venezuela, the most dramatic U.S. intervention in Latin America since the 1989 Panama invasion, in which close to 200 American troops entered Caracas.

Earlier this year, Mr. Trump stated in an interview with *The New York Times* that his morality was the only limit to his power, and only his mind could stop him from exerting it. With data contradicting his many statements, this might be the one that still rings true.



CHART 1: Year-wise number of attacks engaged by the U.S. beyond its borders

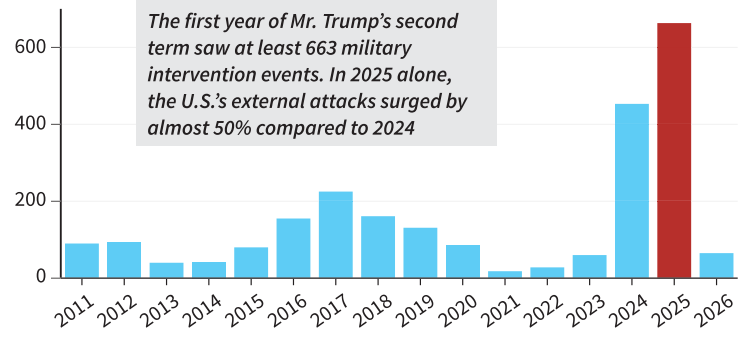


CHART 2: The region-wise number of attacks engaged by the U.S. In the last five years, the U.S.'s involvement increased in West Asia and eastern Africa

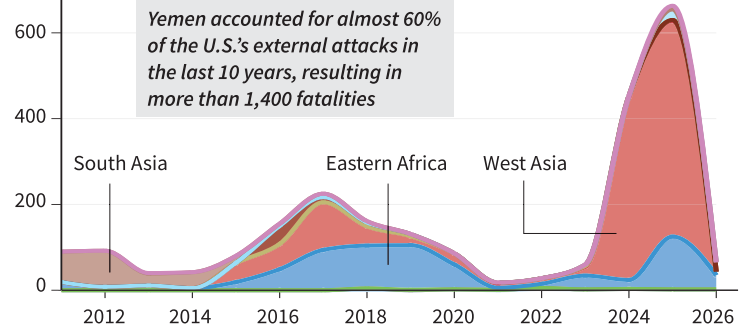
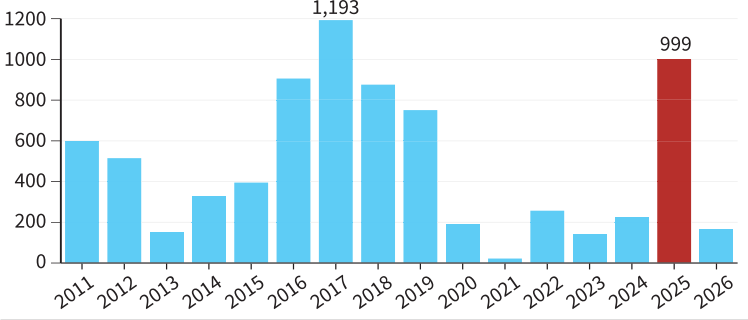


CHART 3: Year-wise number of fatalities in attacks engaged by the U.S. Last year at least a thousand people were killed by U.S.-led forces



FROM THE ARCHIVES

The Hindu.

FIFTY YEARS AGO MARCH 16, 1976

Vijay Amritraj claims two titles: Smith beaten in final

Memphis, Tennessee, March 15: India's Vijay Amritraj dominated the championship match of the World Championship Tennis \$60,000 Memphis Club classic yesterday defeating Stan Smith of the United States 6-2,0-6,6-0.

The 22-year-old right hander picked up \$17,000.

Amritraj broke Smith's service in the second, sixth and eighth games of the first set and claimed it at 6-2.

Smith double faulted on his first two points of the second game and had repeated trouble with his serve.

"I thought the key to the match was Stan's inability to serve," said Amritraj who was unseeded in a field that also included B. Borg B. Lutz, J.D. Newcome, A.J. Roche, and R. Tanner. "He was awful to serve, while I seemed to be returning his serves better than I usually do."

Amritraj swept through the first set with a baseline game which provided winners. He was true on his backhand in crucial situations. "My backhand was good to-day," he said.

Amritraj seemed to lose concentration in the second set as the 29-year-old Smith broke service in the first, third and fifth game on the way to set victory.

In the final set, Amritraj however returned to form and swept through the set in no time.

A HUNDRED YEARS AGO MARCH 16, 1926

The imperial library

Calcutta, March 15: Under the presidency of Mahamahopadhyaya Haraprasad Sastri, a public meeting was held in Albert Hall yesterday, to protest against the proposal of the Government of India for removing the Imperial Library from Calcutta to Delhi. Messages of sympathy with the objects of the meeting, were read from the National Council of Education, the British Indian Association, the Calcutta University, the University Law College and most of the other educational institutions in Calcutta and the mofussil. A Committee was formed to take the necessary steps for retention of the library in Calcutta.

The President pointed out that the library was a transferred subject and that, under the Library Act, the Government could not remove the Imperial Library from Calcutta.

From Page One

State polls from April 9; Bengal to have 2 phases

Ponda in Goa; Bagalkot and Davanagere South in Karnataka; Koridang in Nagaland; and Dharmanagar in Tripura will vote in byelections on April 9. Umreth in Gujarat, and Rahuri and Baramati in Maharashtra will vote on April 23.

The Tamil Nadu Assembly, which has 234 seats, completes its term on May 10, while that of Kerala, which has 140 seats, on May 23. Assam has 126 constituencies, and the term of its Assembly ends on May 20, while the 294-seat West Bengal Assembly completes its term on May 7. The term of the 30-seat Puducherry Assembly ends on June 15.

Asserting that “pure electoral rolls” are the “bedrock of democracy”, Mr. Kumar told the media that the process of special intensive revision (SIR) of electoral rolls was one of the 30 new measures undertaken by the poll panel over the last 12 months to ensure free and fair polls.

The exercise, which began in Bihar last year, has since been held across 13 States and Union Territories. It has been particularly contentious in West Bengal, where the Supreme Court has directed that the over 60 lakh cases listed under “adjudication” be decided by court-appointed judicial officers.

Responding to a question on whether these cases would be disposed of before the scheduled election dates, Mr. Kumar said: “As far as the supplementary list under adjudication is concerned, learned judges are looking into case by case, and those approved by them shall be included in the final electoral rolls by way of a supplementary list, in accordance with the order of the Supreme Court.”

On a question regarding certain schemes announced by West Bengal Chief Minister Mamata Banerjee barely hours before the election dates were declared, the CEC said the “Model Code of Conduct” is applicable from now onwards. Actions taken prior to the MCC is a prerogative of the concerned governments”.

Explaining why Bengal will vote in two phases instead of eight phases as in the previous Assembly polls, he said that the EC held detailed deliberations and in “its considered opinion, it was found necessary to reduce the number of phases and bring it down to an extent where it is convenient for everybody”.

The CEC declined to comment on an Opposition-sponsored motion seeking his removal, submitted in Parliament, saying he did not wish to engage with political statements made by certain political leaders and parties against the EC.

He asserted that elections in all four States and Puducherry shall be conducted in a violence-free and inducement-free manner, and the poll panel would take strict action in case of violations.

About police officers accused of involvement in poll-related violence in the past elections in West Bengal, he said a list has been sought, and necessary action would be taken in accordance with the law.

LPG bookings fall, hint at let-up in panic-buying

“Citizens are advised not to resort to panic buying as adequate stocks of petrol and diesel are available across the country,” the Centre’s update on Sunday said.

Several States and Union Territories, including Bihar, Delhi, Haryana and Rajasthan, have issued orders for allocation of non-domestic LPG in line with government guidelines. The State governments are undertaking enforcement measures to prevent hoarding and black marketing of petrol, diesel and LPG.

Raids are being carried out in several States, including Andhra Pradesh and Bihar, to check hoarding and black marketing of LPG cylinders.

Officials of PSU oil marketing companies are conducting surprise inspections at LPG distributors to ensure smooth supply and prevent irregularities.

Priority sectors continue to receive protected natural gas supplies, including 100% supply for piped natural gas (PNG or natural gas piped to household for cooking purpose) and Compressed Natural Gas, while supplies to industrial and Commercial users have been regulated at about 80%.

Commercial LPG cylinders have been placed at the disposal of State governments for priority distribution and are now available in 30 States and Union Territories, while authorities have stepped up raids and inspections to curb hoarding and black-marketing, it said.

The government has amended the LPG Control Order to mandate that consumers with PNG connections surrender domestic LPG connections, while domestic LPG production from refineries has been maximised and booking intervals rationalised to ensure equitable distribution, it said.

Domestic LPG production from refineries has been maximised, and several supply and demand-side measures have been implemented.

PSU oil marketing companies are promoting digital bookings, discouraging panic bookings and keeping LPG distributorships open on Sundays to facilitate smooth supply.

“Citizens are advised not to panic as the government remains committed to maintaining adequate LPG availability for households and essential sectors,” it said. “Consumers are requested to avoid panic bookings, use digital booking platforms and avoid unnecessary visits to LPG distributors.” Citizens are encouraged to opt for alternate fuels such as PNG wherever possible.

The government also said it is closely monitoring the situation in West Asia while ensuring stable fuel supplies and maritime safety.

RSS backs govt. response to conflict in West Asia

Ishita Mishra
NEW DELHI

The Rashtriya Swayamsevak Sangh (RSS) has backed the Centre’s handling of the West Asia conflict saying New Delhi has acted in the “supreme interest of the nation”.

The response comes amid criticism from the Opposition, particularly the Congress, which has questioned the Centre’s response to developments in West Asia that have sent oil prices soaring, sparking fears of fuel shortage in the country.

“Sangh has no role to play in what all is happening. We only want that there should be peace in the world... I will not analyse the reasons of wars because RSS has no say in the international diplomacy,” RSS general secretary Datatreya Hosabale said on Sunday.

“... The Government of India is doing all that is best possible for the supreme interest of the nation,” he added.

Answering a question on the RSS’s view on those who mourned the death of Iran’s Supreme Leader Ayatollah Ali Khamenei, the RSS general secretary said that expressing grief is “not wrong”.

Cong. cautions govt. on ‘strategic setback’ over Chabahar Port

Jairam Ramesh recounts India’s engagement with the port in Iran since late 1990s, questions lack of allocation for the project in Union Budget

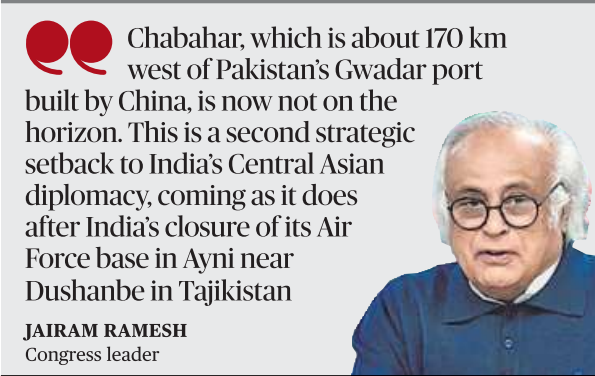
The Hindu Bureau
NEW DELHI

Questioning the Centre’s stance on the Chabahar Port project in Iran, Congress general secretary (communications) Jairam Ramesh on Sunday said that “continuity in governance” was an “essential reality” that the Narendra Modi government refused to acknowledge, and termed the apparent disengagement from the project a strategic setback to India’s outreach in Central Asia.

Mr. Ramesh’s remarks come amid the absence of any allocation for the Chabahar Port in the 2026-27 Union Budget.

In a post on X, he asked, “Does this mean that India has exited, or that its investment commitments for the time being have been fulfilled?”

The Ministry of External Affairs has recently informed Parliament that India has already fulfilled its commitment of contributing \$120 million for procuring port equipment and



that no additional funding is currently due.

“Chabahar, which is about 170 km west of Pakistan’s Gwadar port built by China, is now not on the horizon. This is a second strategic setback to India’s Central Asian diplomacy, coming as it does after India’s closure of its Air Force base in Ayni near Dushanbe in Tajikistan,” Mr. Ramesh said.

Recalling India’s engagement with the project, he said New Delhi began exploring investments in Chabahar in the late 1990s as part of a broader India-Afghanistan-Iran cooperation strategy.

According to Mr. Ramesh, the Union Cabinet approved an initial investment of \$115 million for the project in May 2013. He said this decision was taken even as India was implementing the India-U.S. civil nuclear agreement signed in 2008—an example, he said, of a balanced and strategic foreign policy approach. He also alleged that after coming to power in 2014, the Modi government “repackaged” the Chabahar initiative and projected it as part of the Prime Minister’s own vision without adequately acknowledging the UPA government’s role.

Three years on, justice eludes 2 Kuki-Zo women who were disrobed, paraded and gang-raped in Manipur

Vijaita Singh
NEW DELHI

Nearly three years after two Kuki-Zo women were disrobed, paraded, and gang-raped by a mob in Manipur’s Thoubal district – an attack in which the brother and father of one of the survivors were killed – three accused in the case remain absconding, two are out on bail, and the bail application of another will come up for hearing in the Supreme Court later this month.

The husband of one of the victims, an ex-Army jawan and key witness in the case, told *The Hindu* that a prime suspect identified as Loya, accused of killing the two men, continues to roam free. He alleged that no serious efforts are being made to arrest him. The case is being investigated by the Central Bureau of Investigation (CBI) on the directions of the Supreme Court. The Manipur Police had arrested seven people, including a juvenile, in July 2023.

Pointing to the slow pace of the trial, the wit-

ness said, “We attend the hearings through video-conferencing (trial being held in Guwahati). Justice remains elusive. Two accused are already on bail. The main accused, Loya, who killed the two men, was known to us. Despite the survivor’s statements, he has not been arrested and continues to move around freely. People known to me in the area have told me.”

The victims had fled their village in Kangpokpi district when ethnic violence between Kuki-Zo and Meitei communities erupted on May 3, 2023. According to investigators, a mob of around 1,000 people attacked their village the following day.

A chargesheet filed by the CBI alleges that Loya beat the brother and father of one of the victims to death using a big wooden log and also took part in the sexual assault. The other two accused – Chinglen and Inaoton – named by the survivors for their role in the assault and parading of the women, also remain absconding.



The incident came to national attention after a video clip of the assault went viral, triggering widespread outrage. FILE PHOTO

The incident, which occurred on May 4, 2023, came to national attention only on July 19 that year, after a video clip of the assault went viral, triggering widespread outrage and intervention by the Supreme Court. The case was eventually transferred to the CBI, which filed a chargesheet on October 12, 2023. The trial was shifted to Guwahati as the victims could not travel to the valley areas of Manipur for hearings.

On September 8, 2025, the Gauhati High Court granted bail to two accused – Nameirakpam Ki-

ran Meitei and Arun Khundongbam. While acknowledging the grave allegations against the accused, the court held that continued incarceration without trial cannot be used as pre-trial punishment.

CBI chargesheet

The CBI chargesheet alleged that Khundongbam was part of the mob and played an active role in the sexual assault, gang rape, naked parading of women victims, and murder of two relatives of one victim.

Kiran Meitei is accused of participating in the

Confer Bharat Ratna on Kanshi Ram, says Rahul in letter to PM

The Hindu Bureau
NEW DELHI

The Leader of the Opposition in the Lok Sabha and senior Congress leader, Rahul Gandhi, has urged the government to confer the Bharat Ratna on Kanshi Ram, a Dalit icon and founder of the Bahujan Samaj Party (BSP), describing him as a “symbol of empowerment and hope”.

In a letter to Prime Minister Narendra Modi on Kanshi Ram’s birth anniversary on Sunday, Mr. Gandhi credited him with strengthening the foundations of Indian democracy.

The Congress’s new-found focus on Kanshi Ram, who died in 2006, has irked BSP supremo Mayawati, who cautioned her voters and cadres to be alert to what she described as attempts to appropriate Kanshi Ram’s legacy.

Mr. Gandhi said Kanshi Ram transformed the nature of Indian politics. “Through his movements, he raised political awareness among Bahujans and the poor. He reminded them that their vote, voice, and representation are important, and that this country belongs to everyone equally,” he said in the letter. Kanshi Ram’s ef-



Rahul Gandhi

forts, he added, paved the way for many who had never considered entering public life, to see politics as a means to achieve justice and equality.

“Conferring the Bharat Ratna on him posthumously would recognise his immense contribution to our nation. It would honour the aspirations of millions who continue to view him as a symbol of empowerment and hope,” he added.

Congress president Mallikarjun Kharge said Kanshi Ram’s contribution to the struggle for social justice and equality would remain an inspiration.

Congress general secretary Priyanka Gandhi Vadera described Kanshi Ram as a social justice hero and a fierce voice for deprived and exploited communities.

crime and circulating the assault video. Both were identified by the victims during a test identification parade done virtually.

The chargesheet also stated that policemen present at the scene refused to help the women during the mob assault, allegedly saying the police vehicle had “no key” before leaving them at the mercy of the mob.

According to investigators, the victims escaped through forests over the next 48 hours before reaching safety. The FIR in the case was registered later, after the video surfaced. The CBI said the role of the police personnel is still under investigation. The agency has appealed against the bail granted to the two accused in the Supreme Court.

Another accused, Yumlembam Jiban Singh, has filed a Special Leave Petition (SLP) in the SC, challenging a Gauhati High Court order on December 16, 2025, which rejected his bail plea solely on grounds of the gravity of the alleged offences, des-

pite acknowledging the prolonged incarceration. He is accused of recording and sharing the video of the assault and has sought parity with the two co-accused, who are already out on bail. The Supreme Court is scheduled to hear the matter on March 24.

Three other accused still behind bars are Huiem Herodash Meitei, Ningombam Tomba Singh and Pukhrihongbam Suranjoy Meitei.

A February 26 order of the Supreme Court detailed the status of investigations into Manipur violence cases being monitored by Special Investigation Teams (SIT) under former Maharashtra Police chief Dattatray Padsalgikar, who was appointed by the court on August 7, 2023, to oversee the probe.

The 12th status report submitted by Mr. Padsalgikar on February 18 noted that Manipur has constituted 36 SITs across eight districts to investigate riot-related cases, while 31 serious cases were handed over to the CBI.

Diversify agriculture and encourage farmers to grow pulses, SC tells govt.

Krishnadas Rajagopal
NEW DELHI

The Supreme Court has asked the Union government to revisit its existing policy framework and explore a better substitute under which farmers are incentivised to diversify from conventional crops such as wheat and paddy to pulses.

Besides a relook into policy and diversification of crops, the court asked the Centre to convene a meeting of different stakeholders to look into various issues. These include the absence of an incentivised minimum support



Supreme Court of India

price (MSP), sufficient enough to cover the expenditure that small or medium level farmers incur in producing pulses; guaranteed timely sale of pulse products; and fixation of the cost price of yellow

peas, which are currently being imported, so that it did not impact the home-grown pulses produced by farmers.

A Bench headed by Chief Justice of India Surya Kant said the Centre, through its Ministries of Agriculture, Commerce and Consumer Affairs, and with the aid of subject experts with ground knowledge, mould a framework which would make pulse cultivation worthwhile for farmers.

“There should be a campaign to diversify agriculture. Diversification of paddy is the biggest challenge in North India... Do we re-

quire such a quantity of paddy? We may need for export purposes, but land can also be diverted for pulses. Please ask your Ministries to constitute a committee of people ... somebody who has worked at the ground level, who knows the psyche and compelling circumstances that drive the farming community,” Chief Justice Kant addressed Additional Solicitor-General N. Venkataraman, appearing for the Centre.

The court was hearing a petition filed by Kisan Mahapanchayat, an NGO, seeking curbs on the import of yellow peas.

NC seeks release of Kashmiri youth booked under UAPA

Peerzada Ashiq
SRINAGAR

Scores of youth in Kashmir, who allegedly participated in rallies protesting against the killing of Iran’s Supreme Leader Ayatollah Ali Khamenei, have been detained and booked under the Unlawful Activities Prevention Act.

At a meeting with Jammu and Kashmir Lieutenant-Governor Manoj Sinha on Sunday, a delegation of legislators from the ruling National Conference demanded the withdrawal of such cases before Id.

“FIRs have been registered, including the invocation of provisions under the UAPA, a stringent law whose application against mourners sets a deeply concerning precedent,” said the memorandum jointly filed by the NC legislators, including Tanvir Sadiq, Ali Mohammad Dar, Shameema Firdous, Reyaz Bedar and Hilal Akbar Lone.

“We demand a halt to any further arrests or punitive measures targeting individuals for their participation in these mourning gatherings,” it said.

Cong. takes jibe at EC; says MCC short for 'Modi's Code of Campaign'

Bengal CM announces DA arrears, honorarium hike for religious leaders

Cong. turned Assam into 'land of infiltrators', only BJP can free the State from them: Shah

Take up notice on removal of CEC to dispel doubts: MP

Pure electoral rolls are bedrock of any democracy, says CEC Gyanesh Kumar

Modi lauds Speaker Om Birla's 'impartial' leadership after no-confidence motion fails

CH-CHE

INBRIEF



Bangladeshi man who 'helped Hadi's killers escape' arrested

The Special Task Force of the West Bengal Police on Saturday arrested a Bangladeshi national from Nadia district for allegedly helping the suspected killers of Bangladesh leader Sharif Osman Hadi (in photo) flee to India. The arrest comes a week after the STF arrested two Bangladeshi nationals suspected to be involved in the killing of Hadi. “During interrogation, Philip Sangma admitted that he operates as a tout and facilitates illegal migrants to cross the border through Haluaghat (Bangladesh) - Dalupara (Meghalaya) border area in lieu of money. He also admitted that he had facilitated the two accused in the Hadi murder case to enter India,” the STF said in a statement.

DNT leaders move SC seeking separate count during Census

Members of Denotified, Nomadic and Semi-nomadic Tribe (DNT) communities have approached the Supreme Court, seeking directions that their communities be enumerated distinctly in the 2027 Census with a specific question for this in the forms. The petitioners have said that they have never been counted in any of the Censuses, arguing that the absence of this data has led to community members being unable to avail government benefits. They sought specific directions from the court to the Office of the Registrar General and Census Commissioner of India to include a specific question on the DNTs in both phases of the 2027 Census.

Pakistani terrorist killed near LoC in Baramulla, says Army

An unidentified terrorist was killed close to the Line of Control (LoC) in north Kashmir's Baramulla district on Sunday. The Army said they launched a joint operation in Buchhar, Uri Sector on the night of March 14-15 following a specific infiltration warning from J&K Police. “The alert troops spotted suspicious movement of a terrorist in the thicket. The ambush was readjusted and the terrorist was challenged resulting in the terrorist opening indiscriminate fire. In the contact, a Pakistan terrorist was eliminated. Warlike stores including an AK rifle, pistols and large quantities of ammunition have been recovered,” the Army said.

CBI arrests 'recruiter' tied to overseas cyberscam centres

The Central Bureau of Investigation (CBI) has arrested a person on the charge of recruiting Indian nationals for cyberscam compounds located in foreign jurisdictions, including Cambodia. The accused has been identified as Krishna Kumar Lakhwani from Uttar Pradesh. He allegedly collected about \$300-\$400 per head from job seekers and facilitated their travel to Cambodia via Delhi through different routes, where they were forced to carry out various online frauds targeting victims in India. Based on source information and surveillance, the CBI intercepted the accused upon his arrival in India and brought him to the office for questioning.

Veena exponent Jayanthi Kumaresh to receive Sangita Kalanidhi award at Music Academy's 100th Conference

The Hindu Bureau
CHENNAI

The 100th Conference and Concerts of the The Music Academy, Chennai, beginning in December this year, will be marked by the conferment of the Sangita Kalanidhi award on renowned veena player Jayanthi Kumaresh. Bharatanatyam dancer Narendra G. will receive the Nritya Kalanidhi award.

“The executive committee, at its meeting on March 15, decided to confer the award on her and other awards on various musicians,” said N. Murali, President of the academy, on Sunday.

Ms. Kumaresh, a member of the musically rich Lalgudi G. Jayaraman family, learnt from her mother,



Jayanthi Kumaresh, an exponent of the Saraswati veena, performs in Chennai; and Bharatanatyam dancer Narendra G., who will receive the Nritya Kalanidhi award. B. VELANKANNI RAJ, SPECIAL ARRANGEMENT

Rajalakshmi. She later trained under her aunt Padmavathi Ananthagopalan and then maestro S. Balachander. She also received guidance from her uncle Lalgudi G. Jayaraman, Sangita Kalanidhi T.K. Brinda, composer Thanjavur Sankara Iyer, and T.R. Subramanian.

A postgraduate in English, Ms. Kumaresh is one of the foremost exponents of the Saraswati veena and has collaborated with the late tabla maestro Zakir Hussain. She has contributed in large measure to the present increase in the popularity of the instrument.



Jayanthi Kumaresh, an exponent of the Saraswati veena, performs in Chennai; and Bharatanatyam dancer Narendra G., who will receive the Nritya Kalanidhi award. B. VELANKANNI RAJ, SPECIAL ARRANGEMENT

“It is a great honour that I have been selected for the award in the 100th Conference and Concerts of the Academy, whose logo features Saraswati with a veena. It is an honour not just for me, but for the veena, the national instrument,” Ms. Jayanthi told *The Hindu*.

She said a veena artiste had been selected for the award after a gap of 34 years, and it was a matter of pride that it had happened in the centenary year of her guru, the late S. Balachander.

The Sangita Kala Acharya awards will go to vocalist Sugandha Kalamegam and mridangam player Thrissur C. Narendran. The recipients of the TTK Awards are nagaswaram player Injikudi Subramaniam and violinist T.K.V.B. Ramanujacharyulu.

The Musicologist Award will go to D. Balasubrahmanian, Adjunct Professor of Music and Co-chair of Global South Asian Studies at Wesleyan University. Bharatanatyam dancer A. Jannardhanan will receive the

Nritya Kala Acharya award, a newly instituted award this year. S. Rajeswari will receive the Dance Musician Award (vocal), and T.K. Padmanabhan the Dance Musician Award (instrumental), the other two new dance awards.

Mr. Murali said the Sangita Kalanidhi-designate would preside over the academic sessions of the Annual Conference and Concerts of the Academy to be held between December 15, 2026 and January 1, 2027. She will receive the award along with the other awardees on January 1, the day of Sadas.

Mr. Narendra will receive the Nritya Kalanidhi award at the inauguration of the 20th Annual Dance Festival of the Academy on January 3, 2027.

India-EU ties in focus as Jaishankar visits Brussels

Press Trust of India
NEW DELHI

External Affairs Minister S. Jaishankar on Sunday kick-started a two-day visit to Brussels for talks with his counterparts from member states of European Union.

It is the first high-level visit from India to Brussels-headquartered EU after the two sides firmed up a landmark Free Trade Agreement (FTA) in January.

The External Affairs Ministry said Mr. Jaishankar is travelling to the capital of Belgium at the invitation of EU High Representative and Vice-President Kaja Kallas to interact with Foreign Ministers of the 27 member states of the bloc at its Foreign Affairs Council Meeting.

“During the visit, the External Affairs Minister will also hold meetings with the leadership of the European Union, and his counterparts from Belgium and other EU member states,” the Ministry said. “The visit of the External Affairs Minister coming soon after the historic 16th India-EU summit is expected to further deepen India's strategic partnership with the European Union,” it said.

As the visit is taking place amid the Iran-U.S. conflict, the two sides might deliberate on the flow of energy.

UPSC's new rule: SC nod must for delay in choosing State DGPs

Attorney-General says that there is no provision for UPSC to condone such inordinate delay and proceed as if no irregularity had occurred

S. Vijay Kumar
CHENNAI

The Union Public Service Commission (UPSC) has revised the rules for the empanelment of State Director-General of Police and Head of Police Force.

The State governments will now have to get the consent of the Supreme Court for any delay in submitting the list of DGP-rank officers to the UPSC for empanelment.

While disposing of an interlocutory application moved by the Union Home Ministry, the Supreme Court had ruled that States should send their proposals in anticipation of the vacancies to the UPSC well in time – at least three months prior to the date of retirement of the incumbent on the post of DGP.

It also ordered that “none of the States shall ever conceive of the idea of appointing any person on the post of Director-General of Police on acting basis for there is no concept of acting Director-General of Police as per the decision in Prakash Singh's case”.

With many States delaying the process of sending



The UPSC has revised the rules for the empanelment of State Director-General of Police and Head of Police Force. GETTY IMAGES

proposals for shortlisting the names of three DGPs to the top post for various reasons and some appointing Acting DGPs, the UPSC sought legal opinion in the matter.

The UPSC said “it is observed that many States have been submitting the proposals for convening the Empanelment Committee Meeting in violation of the Supreme Court directions”.

Attorney-General R. Venkataramani opined that the delay by the State government in forwarding names for empanelment was “excessive”.

“On examining the applicable rules and precedents, I find no provision empowering the UPSC to

condone such inordinate delay and then proceed as though no irregularity had occurred, ultimately recommending a panel of DGP,” he said.

The State government should have first come to Supreme Court in case of any difficulty. The more appropriate course, therefore, would be to require the State to seek leave or clarification from the Supreme Court, he noted.

Amending its earlier orders, the UPSC said the States shall seek leave or clarification from the Supreme Court for delayed submission except death, resignation or premature relieving of DGP in accordance with the top court judgment.

Question in U.P. police recruitment exam sparks row

Mayank Kumar
LUCKNOW

The use of the word “pandit” allegedly in bad light in a question in a police recruitment examination in Uttar Pradesh triggered an uproar on Sunday, with political parties and Brahmin social groups questioning the motive of the government and the recruitment body. The word ‘pandit’, which means scholar, is also used to refer to Brahmins.

A question in the written test for sub-inspector (civil police) and equivalent posts, conducted by the Uttar Pradesh Police Recruitment and Promotion Board on March 14, reportedly asked candidates to choose a term for “a person who changes according to circumstances”. The options were Pandit (scholar), *Avsarvadi* (opportunistic), *Nishkapat* (innocent or sincere), and *Sadachari* (virtuous). The option Pandit stoked a row with political parties alleging that it was aimed at presenting the Brahmin community in a derogatory way.

“Such a question shows the mindset of the present government. The word ‘Pandit’ generally refers to Brahmins. Any derogatory words directed at any caste, community, religion or tradition should not be allowed anywhere in a civilised society. I strongly

Chief Minister Yogi Adityanath directed immediate blacklisting of the paper setters

condemn such a question which was asked in the sub-inspector (SI) examination,” said Pramod Tiwari, Deputy Leader of the Opposition in the Rajya Sabha.

Mahesh Pandey, who is associated with the Sarv Brahmin Ekta Sabha, alleged, “Such acts are not accidental; they appear to be part of a deliberate conspiracy to provoke divisions and disturb peace.”

Amid the uproar, Deputy Chief Minister Brajesh Pathak said, “We strongly object to the [answer] options provided for a question in the Uttar Pradesh Police Recruitment Examination. The government has taken serious note of this.” Growing criticism forced Chief Minister Yogi Adityanath to issue directions to all recruitment board chairpersons to ensure that no derogatory remarks are made about the dignity and beliefs of any individual, caste, sect or religious community and directed the blacklisting of the errant paper setters.

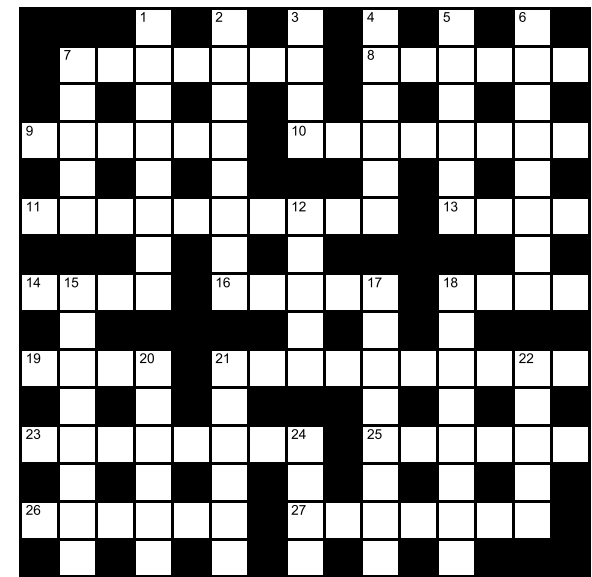
The ruling BJP said that those indulging in such divisive tactics will be dealt with firmly under the law.

THE CROSSWORD+ 14742

(set by Saral)

Solve this puzzle online and access more puzzles at <https://thehindu.com/crosswords>

SCAN TO PLAY



- Across
- 7 Crowded square got hotter (7)
 - 8 Entry of a tax including charges primarily (6)
 - 9 Girl disheartened by long problem (6)
 - 10 Playing shloka, initially bhajan at house (3,5)
 - 11 Gangster controlling English reporters (international) in valley (10)

- 13 Repaired sherwani, every now and then (4)
 - 14 Nearly squeeze large plant (4)
 - 16 Almost escape running in gap (5)
 - 18 Team leaders from several industrial departments enter (4)
 - 19 Shortly examine stable (4)
 - 21 Native sailor fixing an oil rig (10)
 - 23 Fellow least bothered about one Victor in party (8)
 - 25 Creating new image for riddle (6)
 - 26 Leave power grabbing society (6)
 - 27 Golden brown durians at first in fruit garden (7)
- Down
- 1 Finished a type of exam relating to rural life (8)
 - 2 Stress from mishaps sadly after drug (8)
 - 3 Heroine is dancing only lambada from the beginning (4)
 - 4 Knocked over container, spilling ink? Getting towel (6)
 - 5 Drops fights (6)
 - 6 Avoided shredded cheese with salad in the end (8)
 - 7 Perhaps loves to answer (5)
 - 12 Harry hid a ring in this place (5)
 - 15 Banks essentially tried badly to catch that man owing money (2,3,3)
 - 17 Height of wall not fine outside pit (8)
 - 18 Mark covering object below one master's weapon (8)
 - 20 Check and tie roughly (6)
 - 21 Arrival of a director before opening (6)
 - 22 Targeted media by mistake (5)
 - 24 John finally left stolen goods (4)

SUDOKU



Solution to previous puzzle

Solution to yesterday's Sudoku

FAITH

Actions to refrain from

In one of his discourses, Dr. Venkatesh explained that Vidura narrated to Dhritarashtra that certain actions undertaken by human beings may not yield desired results and may ultimately prove futile.

Teaching unworthy or undeserving disciples will never bear fruit. It becomes a sheer waste of time and energy for both the teacher and the student. A true teacher should discern a disciple's capacity and receptiveness before imparting knowledge. If a teacher boasts about having taught an incapable student, such self-praise does not deserve admiration.

Likewise, a person should avoid unnecessary interaction with those who harbour dislike or hatred toward him, for such association will only lead to unpleasantness and discord. In the same way, if a man rescues a woman from danger, he should not glorify himself as a hero. Performing a noble act and then boasting about it diminishes its true value.

It is futile to seek or expect financial assistance from a miser, for such a person is unwilling to part with his wealth even for a worthy cause. Likewise, a person who praises himself and expects others to bestow name and fame upon him does not engage in a commendable or respectable act.

A person who involves himself in unwanted and undesirable activities out of arrogance or recklessness deserves condemnation. It is also useless to discuss a matter with someone who has neither trust nor interest in it. Similarly, making efforts to obtain something that is impossible to acquire is nothing but a futile exercise.

Choosing the right personal loan lender



With rising frauds, choosing a dependable lender is important. GETTY IMAGES/ISTOCK

Santosh Agarwal

One of the first steps while applying for a personal loan involves reviewing your eligibility and shortlisting lenders whose requirements align with your needs and profile. Choosing the right lender can have a significant impact on both the overall borrowing cost and the borrowing experience. Careful evaluation of key metrics is required to choose the most suitable lender for you.

After shortlisting the potential lenders, borrowers should further narrow down available offers to find the best fit. Differences in minimum income thresholds, employment stability requirements and credit score expectations can influence both approval chances and processing timelines. Evaluating these factors in advance can help reduce application friction and lead to faster loan disbursal. At the same time, borrowers should also check their eligibility with lenders with whom they have an existing relationship. Banks and NBFCs usually prefer borrowers from their existing customer base.

Interest rates

The interest rate on your personal loan influences the total cost of borrowing. Even a slight difference in interest rates can help save considerably over the course of the loan tenure. Therefore, the interest rate should be an important metric of comparison while choosing a lender.

However, a genuine point of confusion pertains to the actual cost of the loan for borrowers. Most usually consider only the interest rate, leaving behind other charges that add to the cost of the loan. For a holistic view, borrowers should rely not just on the advertised rate, but also on the Annual Percentage Rate (APR). The APR provides borrowers with a complete picture of all fees and charges associated with the loan.

Ease of borrowing

The borrowing experience also plays an important role in choosing the right lender. Features such as digital processes, minimum documentation, quick approvals, and easy repayment tracking can simplify loan application and management. This becomes more important, especially in cases where access to funds quickly is of utmost importance.

Tenure flexibility

While tenure flexibility should not be a primary deciding factor, those seeking repayment terms aligned with their cash flow should consider lenders offering flexibility. Additionally, look for lenders who do not have a lock-in period or strict prepayment or foreclosure terms. The loan tenure impacts the overall interest outgo and the monthly EMI affordability. Lenders having varying maximum loan amount thresholds are often preferred by applicants who need a higher loan amount. Choosing a lender that offers the required loan amount without stringent terms and conditions helps borrowers meet their financial needs smoothly.

Another important aspect borrowers should consider when choosing a lender is their regulatory standing. With the risk of fraud and an increase in the incidents of data breaches, choosing a dependable lender becomes all the more important. Borrowing from a reputed lender ensures transparent policies and reliable service throughout the loan tenure. Even in scenarios where offers from reputed lenders are few, borrowers should refrain from borrowing from lenders not regulated by the RBI.

(The writer is CEO, Paisabazaar)



The math of delay will be brutally unforgiving. ILLUSTRATION BY B. SAINATH

Why pension planning can no longer be optional

In modern India, growing old without being financially prepared is a risk many cannot afford as a government pension or the comfort of a large joint family can no longer be relied upon

RETIRE IN PEACE

Vishwajeet Goel

There was a time when retirement in India was largely someone else's responsibility. A government pension or the comfort of a large joint family often filled the gap. That reality, however, has changed quietly but decisively. Today, the burden of retirement security is shifting squarely onto individuals and households. If we do not plan early and deliberately, the cost of delay can quickly become overwhelming.

The uncomfortable truth is simple. In modern India, growing old without being financially prepared is a risk many households can no longer afford.

Pension gap is real India has made visible progress in financial inclusion. Bank account ownership is widespread, and market linked retirement products are gaining traction.

Yet beneath the surface, the pension safety net remains thin.

Recent analysis shows that formal retirement schemes such as EPFO, NPS and Atal Pension Yojana together cover less than 25% of the workforce. That means the vast majority of India's working population is either underprepared or completely unprepared for retirement.

Even broader financial behaviour tells a similar story. While more than

Family structures are evolving and the traditional assumption that children will financially support ageing parents is becoming less reliable

78% of Indian adults have bank accounts, fewer than 14% participate in any formal pension or retirement scheme.

At the same time, the organised pension ecosystem is expanding. The National Pension System alone had over 2.1 crore subscribers and assets of over ₹16 lakh crore by December 2025, reflecting strong growth in market linked retirement saving. The direction is encouraging. The scale of the gap is still daunting.

The math of delay is brutally unforgiving.

Consider a simple retirement goal. Assume an individual wants to build a retirement corpus of ₹5 crore by age 60 and expects a long term return of 12% through disciplined investing.

If the investor starts at age 30, the required monthly SIP is roughly ₹16,229. Delay the decision by just 10 years and start at 40, and the monthly requirement jumps sharply to about ₹54,357. Wait until age 50, and the number becomes daunting, with the required monthly investment rising to nearly ₹2.23 lakh.

Inflation continues to erode purchasing power. What looks like a comfortable retirement corpus today may prove inadequate two or three decades later

The message is hard to ignore. The goal remains the same, but the cost of delay rises dramatically. In retirement planning, time does the heavy lifting. The longer we wait, the heavier the monthly burden becomes. This is the hidden tax of procrastination. We often focus on market timing, product selection, or short term returns. But the single most powerful variable in retirement planning remains time in the market, not timing the market.

Why the traditional safety nets are no longer enough: Several structural shifts are reshaping retirement risk in India.

First, life expectancy is rising. Indians are living longer, which is a positive development, but it also means retirement periods are stretching to 25 to 30 years in many cases.

Second, the nature of employment is changing. Gig work, self employment and informal work arrangements are expanding, most often without built in retirement benefits.

Third, family structures are evolving. The traditional assumption that children will financially support ageing parents is

becoming less reliable in urban India.

Finally, inflation continues to erode purchasing power. What looks like a comfortable retirement corpus today may prove inadequate two or three decades later.

Taken together, these trends make one conclusion unavoidable. Pension planning is no longer optional. It is foundational financial planning.

The rise of market linked retirement solutions: The good news is India's retirement ecosystem is becoming more sophisticated and accessible.

Market linked options such as the National Pension System are gaining acceptance because they combine long term growth potential with disciplined accumulation. The rapid growth in NPS assets reflects this behavioural shift. These products matter because traditional approaches alone may struggle to beat long term inflation. For younger investors especially, exposure to equity through structured retirement vehicles can meaningfully improve outcomes over long horizons.

However, product availability is only half the story. Behavioural adoption remains the bigger challenge. The window is open, but not forever.

In today's India, wealth creation and retirement planning cannot be sequential goals. They must happen together.

(The writer is head, Pensionbazaar.com)

To adjust or not to adjust the benchmark

THINKINVESTOR

Venkatesh Bangaruswamy

Alpha is the excess return a portfolio generates over an "appropriate" benchmark. An "appropriate" benchmark means a fund's alpha will be useful for evaluation only if it holds stocks from the chosen benchmark. Regulation allows large-cap funds to invest not more than 20% in stocks outside of the benchmark. So, comparison of a large-cap fund's performance to its benchmark may not be technically meaningful. Previously in this column, we discussed why a blended benchmark (say, 80% large-cap and 20% mid-cap index) may be optimal. Such blended benchmarks are not easy to create for individual investors. In this article, we discuss when it is acceptable, though not necessarily accurate, to compare large-cap fund performance to its large-cap benchmark.

Relative performance

Relative performance is important for active funds. This relative performance works at two levels. At the first level is the comparison of the fund's performance with its benchmark index. This determines the fund's alpha. Is the fund true to its benchmark? If not, it is preferable to create an appropriate benchmark to evaluate the fund. At the second level is peer comparison. How has the fund performed relative to its peers in the large-cap style universe? It is this comparison that we discuss below.

Enabled by the SEBI regulation, most large-cap funds invest in mid-cap stocks within the 20% limit. But the decision to invest outside the benchmark is choice of a fund manager. A fund manager will invest in mid-cap stocks only if she believes that mid-caps will outperform large-cap stocks. So, choosing to invest outside the benchmark is an active decision. This decision can result in positive alpha, which is function of both skill and luck. Hence, comparing a fund's alpha with its peers without adjusting for the outside-benchmark investment may be acceptable.

Conclusion

It is accurate to evaluate a large-cap active fund using an appropriate blended benchmark.

The argument is that the fund must have outperformed the benchmark despite carrying similar risk. This argument is meaningful if you are investing in large-cap funds to achieve your life goals. Why? Exposure to mid-cap stocks can be risky.

A blended benchmark can help you understand how strongly the fund's returns are related to the mid-cap stock performance.

When you are investing surplus cash in a large-cap fund, it is more practical to use the given benchmark, as the primary objective is to earn consistently higher alpha returns compared with peers.

(The author offers training programmes for individuals to manage their personal investments)

Personal Loans

Rates and Charges		Loan amount 5 lakh Tenure 5 years	Loan amount 1 lakh Tenure 5 years	(% of loan amount)
Name of Lender	Interest Rate (%)	EMI (Rs)	EMI (Rs)	Processing fee
HDFC Bank	9.99 onwards	10,621 onwards	2,124 onwards	Up to Rs 6,500
Tata Capital	10.99 onwards	10,869 onwards	2,174 onwards	Up to 3.5%
State Bank of India	10.00-15.00	10,624-11,895	2,125-2,379	Up to 1.50% (Rs. 1,000 - Rs. 15,000)
ICICI Bank	9.99 onwards	10,621 onwards	2,124 onwards	Up to 2%
Bank of Baroda*	10.15-18.00	10,660-12,710	2,132-2,542	Up to 2% (Max. Rs 10,000)
Axis Bank	9.50 onwards	10,501 onwards	2,100 onwards	Up to 2%
Kotak Mahindra Bank	10.99 onwards	10,869 onwards	2,174 onwards	Up to 5%
Bank of India	10.85-16.15	10,834-12,199	2,167-2,440	Up to 1% (Min. Rs 250; Max. Rs 15,000)
Canara Bank	9.70-15.15	10,550-11,934	2,110-2,387	0.50% (Rs 1,000 - Rs 5,000)
Punjab National Bank	10.25-16.80	10,685-12,373	2,137-2,475	Up to 1%
HSBC Bank	9.95 onwards	10,611 onwards	2,122 onwards	Up to 2%
Federal Bank	11.75 - 18.99	11,059 - 12,968	2,212 - 2,594	Up to 3%
Union Bank of India	8.75 - 12.55	10,319-11,262	2,064-2,252	Up to 1% (Max. Rs 7,500)
Bajaj Finserv	10.00-30.00	10,624-16,177	2,125-3,235	Up to 3.93%
Punjab & Sind Bank	9.60-13.85	10,525-11,595	2,105-2,319	0.50%-1%
Indian Overseas Bank	10.25 onwards	10,685 onwards	2,137 onwards	Up to 0.75%
UCO Bank	9.95 - 13.20	10,611-11,428	2,122-2,286	Up to 1% (Min. Rs 750)
IDFC FIRST Bank	9.99 onwards	10,621 onwards	2,124 onwards	Up to 3.5%
Bank of Maharashtra	8.75-13.55	10,319-11,518	2,064-2,304	Up to 1% (Max. Rs 10,000)
Central Bank of India	9.85-11.65	10,587-11,034	2,117-2,207	Up to 1%
IndusInd Bank	10.49 onwards	10,744 onwards	2,149 onwards	Up to 3.5% (2% for instant personal loans for limited period)

*Interest concession of 0.10% to customers opting for group credit life insurance
Rates and charges as of March 11

Car Loans

Rates and Charges		Loan amount 5 lakh Tenure 5 years	(% of loan amount)
Name of Lender	Interest Rate (%)	EMI (Rs)	Processing fee
Union Bank of India	7.40-9.45	9,995 - 10,489	Up to Rs 1,000
Punjab National Bank	7.55-10.70	10,031 - 10,797	Up to 0.25% (Rs. 1,000 - Rs. 1,500)
Bank of Baroda	7.60 - 11.35	10,043 - 10,959	Up to Rs. 2,000
Canara Bank	7.45-11.45	10,007 - 10,984	0.25% (Rs 1,000 - Rs 5,000)
Bank of India	7.60-12.55	10,043 - 11,262	Up to 0.25% (Rs. 2,500 - Rs. 10,000)
UCO Bank	7.35-10.00	9,983 - 10,624	0.5% (Max. Rs 5,000)
State Bank of India	8.70 - 9.85	10,355 - 10,587	Rs 750 - Rs 1,500
Bank of Maharashtra*	7.45-11.75	10,007 - 11,059	NIL
Indian Overseas Bank	7.55-12.00	10,031 - 11,122	NIL
ICICI Bank	8.50 onwards	10,258 onwards	Up to 2%
HDFC Bank	8.20 onwards	10,186 onwards	Up to 0.5% (Rs. 3,500 - Rs. 8,000)
Karnataka Bank	8.00-11.50	10,138 - 10,996	Up to 0.60% (Rs. 2,500 - Rs. 11,000)
Federal Bank	7.60-9.00	10,198 onwards	Rs. 2,000 - Rs. 4,500
Punjab and Sind Bank**	7.50-14.00	10,019 - 11,634	0.25% (Rs. 1,000 - Rs. 15,000)
Indian Bank	7.50-9.65	10,019 - 10,513	Rs. 1,200
IDFC FIRST Bank	9.99 onwards	10,621 onwards	Up to Rs. 10,000
Central Bank of India	7.60-9.20	10,043 - 10,428	No processing fees till 31.03.2026

*0.25% interest rate concession for home loan borrowers/customers with at least 6 months of relationship with bank.
**Concession of up to 50% on processing fee for PSB Apna Vahan Sugam.

Rates and charges as on March 11

Source: Paisabazaar.com

North Korea conducts test of nuclear-capable rocket launchers



UAE orders expedited trial of 10 for publishing misleading video

Israeli soldiers fire on family car in occupied West Bank, killing four



Iran says women's football captain withdraws Australia asylum bid

 $MCH-CH_2$

Sport

BREAKTHROUGH

An emotional Antonelli thanks his team after realising dream



REUTERS

He has been defined as Lewis Hamilton’s successor and George Russell’s teammate at Mercedes. Now Kimi Antonelli is a Formula1 race-winner. “I am speechless. I am about to cry. Thank you so much to my team because they helped me achieve this dream,” said the 19-year-old after his win at the Chinese GP.

HUNGRY FOR MORE

Ferrari has its work cut out to beat Mercedes, admits Hamilton



GETTY IMAGES

It is really special to see Mercedes back at the front because it is a phenomenal team. I know that we have got our work cut out to beat it. Because when it is on form like this, it is not easy to beat it — Ferrari driver Lewis Hamilton on competition with Mercedes for the rest of the Formula One season.

WAR FALLOUT

Bahrain and Saudi F1 races to be a non-starter in April due to conflict



FILE PHOTO: REUTERS

The Formula One races in Bahrain and Saudi Arabia have been cancelled as the West Asia war engulfs the region. “While several alternatives were considered, it was ultimately decided that no substitutions will be made in April,” said the International Automobile Federation (FIA), the motorsport governing body.

VICTORY TO SAVOUR

Bangladesh edges Pakistan in a thriller, takes ODI series



AFF

Bangladesh won the three-match ODI series against Pakistan 2-1 after recording a thrilling 11-run win in the final match in Dhaka on Sunday. **The scores:** Bangladesh 290/5 in 50 overs (Tanzid Hasan 107, Litton Das 41, Towhid Hridoy 48 n.o.) bt Pakistan 279 in 50 overs (Salman Agha 106, Taskin Ahmed 4/49).

Antonelli drives an almost flawless race for maiden win

The Italian becomes the second-youngest to claim a Grand Prix after Verstappen; Mercedes’ early dominance continues after another 1-2 finish; Hamilton secures his first podium with Ferrari; both McLarens fail to start the race

CHINESE GP

Agencies
SHANGHAI

An emotional Kimi Antonelli won a Grand Prix for the first time on Sunday.

In the Chinese GP, the 19-year-old finished ahead of Mercedes teammate George Russell and Lewis Hamilton, who secured his maiden podium for Ferrari.

Antonelli converted being the youngest pole-sitter in Formula One history into victory after both McLarens dramatically failed to start the Shanghai race.

The only driver younger than Antonelli to win a Grand Prix is Max Verstappen, who was 18 when he bagged his first victory in 2016.

Antonelli briefly lost the lead at the start but once he got back in front, he controlled the pace to cruise home by more than five seconds from Russell. Charles Leclerc was fourth in the second Ferrari.

It was a flawless drive from the youngest, apart from one heart-fluttering moment when he locked up at the hairpin on his penultimate lap.

But he recovered to avoid nothing more damaging than a small excursion off track.

Four-time World champion Max Verstappen continued Red Bull’s poor start to the new season when he was told to retire his car on lap 46.

Oliver Bearman was fifth in the Haas, followed home by Pierre Gasly (Alpine) and Liam Lawson (RB).

The results:

1. Antonelli (Mercedes) 1h 33m 15.607s, 2. Russell (Mercedes) +5.515s, 3. Hamilton (Ferrari) +25.267s, 4. Leclerc (Ferrari) +28.894s, 5. Bearman (Haas) +57.268s, 6. Gasly (Alpine) +59.647s, 7. Lawson (Racing Bulls) +1m 20.588s, 8. Hadjar (Red Bull) +1m 27.247s, 9. Sainz Jr (Williams) +1 lap, 10. Colapinto (Alpine) +1 lap, 11. Hulkenberg (Audi) +1 lap, 12. Lindblad (Racing Bulls) +1 lap, 13. Bottas (Cadillac) +1 lap, 14. Ocon (Haas) +1 lap, 15. Perez (Cadillac) +1 lap.
Retirements: 10th lap: Stroll (Aston Martin), **33rd lap:** Alonso (Aston Martin), **46th lap:** Verstappen (Red Bull).
DNS: Bortoletto (Audi), Piastri (McLaren), Norris (McLaren), Albon (Williams).
Championship: Drivers: 1. Russell 51 points, 2. Antonelli 47, 3. Leclerc 34, 4. Hamilton 33, 5. Bearman 17, 6. Norris 15, 7. Gasly 9, 8. Verstappen 8, 9. Lawson 8, 10. Lindblad 4, 11. Hadjar 4, 12. Piastri 3, 13. Bortoletto 2, 14. Sainz Jr 2, 15. Colapinto 1.
Constructors: 1. Mercedes 98 points, 2. Ferrari 67, 3. McLaren 18, 4. Haas 17, 5. Red Bull 12, 6. Racing Bulls 12, 7. Alpine 10, 8. Audi 2, 9. Williams 2.

Lights to flag

THE JOURNEY IN NUMBERS AFTER THE 56-LAP RACE IN SHANGHAI

1 Antonelli is the first Italian to win a Formula 1 race since Fisichella (2006 Malaysian GP)

1 With his first podium for Ferrari in his 26th race for the team, Hamilton has become the first driver to have podium finishes with three of Formula One’s most successful teams (Mercedes 153 and McLaren 49)

2 Antonelli (19y 202d) is the second youngest F1 winner after Verstappen (18y 228d), and the youngest ever to convert

pole position to victory

2 Leclerc overtakes Raikkonen to become second in the list of most Ferrari starts

7 For the seventh successive season, Verstappen has failed to finish on the podium in the race immediately preceding the Japanese GP

1

Hamilton has shared the podium with Rosberg, Russell and Antonelli in each of their first F1 wins

7 Mercedes has registered 1-2 finishes at each of the first two Grands Prix in a season for the first time since 2019 (Hamilton and Bottas), making it the seventh time in F1 history

13 Ferrari and Mercedes have extended their record for most podium finishes in China

14 Hamilton has extended his record of points-scoring finishes at the Chinese GP

17 Bearman’s strong start to 2026 has seen him garner more points than the last two World champions (Norris 15 and Verstappen 8)

20 Hamilton’s first Ferrari podium in China has come 20 years after fellow seven-time F1 World champion Schumacher’s final podium with the Prancing Horse at the same venue

34 This is the first podium made up exclusively of British and Italian drivers in 34 years (Mansell, Patrese and Brundle at the 1992 British GP)

51 For the first time after more than five decades, an Italian has taken the top spot and two British drivers have completed the podium (Brambilla, Hunt and Pryce. 1975 Austrian GP)

Compiled by ANIRUDH VELAMURI & S. DIPAK RAGAV



X@F1

Dowman’s show and Man City’s draw put Arsenal in control

EURO LEAGUES

Agence France-Presse
LONDON

Max Dowman, 16, propelled Arsenal closer to the title by becoming the Premier League’s youngest ever goalscorer in a dramatic 2-0 win against Everton on Saturday while Manchester City stumbled in a 1-1 draw at West Ham United.

Mikel Arteta’s men are edging towards a first league title in 22 years as their advantage over City, which has a game in hand, now stands at nine points.

Arsenal struggled to break down obdurate Everton until the teenage substitute turned the game in the final moments.

Viktor Gyokeres finally found a way through in the 89th minute, with a helping hand from Everton goalkeeper Jordan Pickford, who flapped at Dowman’s cross.

There was still time for Dowman to run the length of the pitch and slot into an empty net with Pickford coming up for an Everton

corner in stoppage time.

Aged just 16 years and 73 days, Dowman is now the youngest scorer in Premier League and Arsenal’s history.

City’s season is in danger of coming off the rails as West Ham clung on for a point that lifted it out of the relegation zone for the first time in three months.

In LaLiga, Barcelona thrashed Sevilla 5-2 to restore its four-point lead on Sunday after Real Madrid beat Elche on Saturday.

The results: Premier League: Crystal Palace 0 drew with Leeds 0; Manchester United 3 (Casemiro 53, Cunha 71, Sesko 81) bt Aston Villa 1 (Barkley 64); Liverpool 1 (Szoboszlai 18) drew with

Tottenham 1 (Richarlison 90).

LaLiga: Barcelona 5 (Raphinha 9-pen, 21-pen, 51, Olmo 38, Cancelo 60) bt Sevilla 2 (Oso 45+4, Sow 90+2).

On Saturday:

Premier League: Sunderland 0 lost to Brighton 1 (Minteh 58); Burnley 0 drew with Bournemouth 0; Chelsea 0 lost to Newcastle 1 (Gordon 18); Arsenal 2 (Gyokeres 89, Dowman 90+7) bt Everton 0; West Ham 1 (Mavropanos 35) drew with Manchester City 1 (Silva 31).

LaLiga: Atletico Madrid 1 (Molina 8) bt Getafe 0; Real Madrid 4 (Rudiger 39, Valverde 45, Huijsen 66, Guler 89) bt Elche 1 (Manuel Angel 85).

Serie A: Napoli 2 (Hojlund 46, Politano 67) bt Lecce 1 (Siebert 3); Udinese 0 lost to Juventus 1 (Boga 38).



Making history: Dowman rolls the ball into an open Everton goal to become Premier League’s and Arsenal’s youngest scorer. REUTERS

Gill and Smriti win top honours at BCCI awards



Special occasion: Binny, Dravid, and Mithali receive the Col. C.K. Nayudu Lifetime Achievement Award from ICC chair Jay Shah on Sunday. BCCI

CRICKET

Press Trust of India
NEW DELHI

Shubman Gill and Smriti Mandhana were named the Best International Cricketers at the BCCI Naman Awards 2026 here on Sunday, recognising their outstanding performances in the 2024-25 season.

Gill won the prestigious Polly Umrigar Award, while Smriti received the honour for the fifth time. For Gill, it was his second Cricketer of the Year award after first winning it in 2023.

Legends Roger Binny, Rahul Dravid and Mithali

Major award winners

Col. C.K. Nayudu Lifetime Achievement Award: Roger Binny, Rahul Dravid and Mithali Raj.

Best International Cricketer (men): Shubman Gill.

Best International Cricketer (women): Smriti Mandhana.

Best international debut (men): Harshit Rana.

Best international debut (women): Shree Charani.

Raj were honoured with the Col. C.K. Nayudu Lifetime Achievement Award, the BCCI’s highest honour.

Gill enjoyed a stellar 2025. On the tour of England, he led from the front in the five-Test series, finishing as the top run-get-

ter with 754 runs in 10 innings. The 26-year-old also played a pivotal role in India’s Champions Trophy triumph last year. He made an unbeaten 101 against Bangladesh in India’s opening match, and ended the tournament with 188 runs.

Smriti finished 2025 with 1,703 international runs, including 1,362 in ODIs, the most by any woman in a calendar year. In doing so, the left-hander also became the first batter in women’s ODI history to score 1,000 runs in a calendar year. The Indian vice-captain aggregated 434 runs in nine matches during the team’s maiden ODI World Cup title triumph.

Pole vaulter Baranica makes Asiad grade

Ashwin Achal
BENGALURU

JSW’s Pooja claimed the women’s high jump crown in the fifth Indian Open jumps competition at the Anju Bobby High Performance Centre here on Sunday.

Pooja’s 1.76m winning effort fell short of the qualification standard for the Asian Games 2026 (1.80m) and Commonwealth Games 2026 (1.92m).

Tamil Nadu’s Baranica Elangovan won women’s pole vault, and attained the Asian Games 2026 mark (4.10m).

With 2003 World Championships long jump bronze medallist Anju Bobby George in attendance, Mubassina Mohammed won the women’s long

jump gold.

The Lakshadweep-born Mubassina, now representing Anju Bobby Sports Foundation, finished ahead of nearest rival Bhavani Yadav (6.27m) with her sixth and final jump of 6.38m.

The results (winners): Men:

Under-20: Long jump: K. Yuvaraj (NCOE, Tvm), 7.63m.

Under-18: Long jump: Rajeev Roy (NCOE, Trivandrum), 7.45m.

Women: Pole vault: Baranica Elangovan (TN), 4.10m. **Long jump:** Mubassina Mohammed (Anju Bobby Sports Foundation), 6.38m. **High jump:** Pooja (JSW), 1.76m. **Triple jump:** Mallala Anusha (AP), 13.18m.

Under-20: Long jump: Tamanna (Har), 5.93m. **High jump:** Pooja (Anju Bobby Sports Foundation), 1.74m.

Under-18: High jump: R. Harshini (TN), 1.50m. **Long jump:** Kashish (Har), 5.58m.



Bittersweet: Pooja won women’s high jump but missed out on Asian Games qualification. SUDHAKARA JAIN

EDUCATIONPLUS

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Salil Sahadevan

In the mid-19th century, an Austrian monk bred generations of pea plants in his monastery garden with meticulous care. He mapped their traits, recorded the results, and published them in an unknown journal. He went back to his regular teaching, and his work went unnoticed.

Decades later, biologists revisited his paper and notes in the margins and found that his experiments revealed the basis of heredity. Once a forgotten footnote, the garden experiment became the seed of modern genetics, and Gregor Mendel its father.

Forgotten in the margins

A century later, British chemist Rosalind Franklin captured an X-ray image that revealed the double helix structure of DNA. Known as Photo 51, it was within the footnote of her lab logs and might have remained unseen until Watson and Crick allegedly used it to claim the breakthrough leading to the Nobel Prize, leaving Franklin in the margins for years.

Sometimes, we look too late into the margins of knowledge. In the 14th century, Kerala mathematician Sangamagrama Madhava charted the infinite series for sine, cosine, and approximated pi, long before Newton or Leibniz.

His work remained obscure until Charles M. Whish, an East India Company official, highlighted the Kerala School. Later,



GETTY IMAGES/ISTOCKPHOTO

Following a footnote

Breakthrough learning often hides in footnotes and margins. How can we train ourselves to value these overlooked learning spaces?

historian George Gheverghese Joseph furthered this recognition. Recently, Malayalam professor Litty Chacko uncovered unpublished fragments of the works of Madhava after two decades of sifting through thousands of palm-leaf manuscripts.

When I asked how, she replied, “From the margins, always from the margins.”

The main narratives miss what matters most. The surprise is in the margins and footnotes, where few look. This is more so, as we tend to shrink every communication into shorts, snippets and capsules.

Age of compression
We live in the age of compression bias, where news is reduced to push alerts

and books condensed into summaries. See the same logic in our conversations when we say “cut to the chase” or “give me the gist”. It is convenient and efficient, but comes at a cost.

The margins, where novelty often begins, are erased in summarisation, causing what does not fit to disappear. By ignoring the peripheries, we risk recycling old ideas.

Why do these margins matter? They hold the pieces of knowledge that do not have a home as yet in the mainstream story. They hold contradictions, odd questions, and failed attempts as raw materials for new knowledge, making margins and footnotes intellectual commons free from the pressures of popularity and marketability.

Keeping them alive
So how do we keep the margins alive? Make spaces for incidental learning. You follow one idea and a note at the bottom opens a new door.

The thrill of chasing a reference chain teaches a kind of thinking that uses the courage to wander. Serendipity thrives in those knowledge wanderings. If we do not do this, there is a personal loss. Students raised only on summaries and MCQs become efficient consumers but shallow explorers.

In classrooms, it starts with design. Assign work that requires citations. Pick a Wikipedia page on a topic and follow a few linked pages in sequence, noting how each click bends the conversation in unexpected ways, turning a single fact into a series of discoveries.

From a passage with rich footnotes, try tracing references back to their source to find surprising insights that did not make it into the main text.

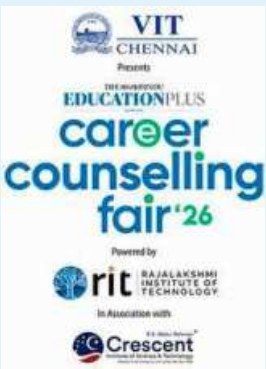
Do this with an AI-based citation network, even if that may lead nowhere. Explore connections in ancient texts and palm-leaves using Machine Learning and create spaces for open-ended research where the outcome is unknown.

Note: Exciting rabbit holes often begin at the edges of the page, where the next chapter starts.

Views expressed in this article are personal

The writer is Deputy Secretary with the University Grants Commission and an education design researcher at IIT-Hyderabad.

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OFF THE EDGE
Nandini Raman

Prepare honestly

Uncertain about your career options? Low on self-confidence? This column may help

I am preparing for competitive exams, but feel mentally exhausted. I used to be a topper, but I am struggling with consistency and motivation. Why is this happening. Kanagavalli

Dear Kanagavalli,
This could be a mix of much that you are feeling right now: performance anxiety, others' expectations of you (living up to being a topper), your own identity crisis, peer pressure and just sheer cognitive burnout.

Competitive exams do not guarantee success; they are a process in themselves, and often laborious. They are uncertain, hard, long, repetitive, and have long portions.

So maybe there is some self-doubt creeping in as well: what if I fail and don't make it?

Meet a therapist and claim your sense of calm, confidence, and study habits. Only preparation and performance are in your control. Nothing else!

Reclaim your self-worth and prepare sincerely, honestly, and earnestly. If this exam is not meant to be, work on your Plan B and C. Something better is always in store! Do not limit yourself by feeling under-confident.

I graduated from Jammu University (distance education) in 2022 and live in a rural area near the international border. I am now preparing for the Civil Services exam. Sometimes, I feel demotivated because of my educational background and struggle with confidence and

communication skills.
Sehaj

Dear Sehaj,
What you are feeling is common and has nothing to do with your intelligence or potential.

Civil Services officers are also selected from distance education, state universities, rural and remote regions, and first-generation learners. The exam rewards clarity of thought, consistency, resilience and ability to learn and apply.

Your background is not a disadvantage but a strength because you understand grassroots realities, have probably seen governance gaps firsthand, and know what exclusion feels like.

Why are you feeling demotivated? Do not compare yourself to English-medium toppers, coaching narratives, or social media success stories. Getting stuck in identity conflict and believing a narrative of isolation will only impact your confidence and communication further.

Good communication is not a fluent English accent. It is about structured thinking, clarity, simplicity and honesty. Start reading the newspaper out loud. Summarise what you read in your own words, record yourself (audio), and you will hear improvement within a month.

Use online discussions and peer groups to get help and motivate yourself.

I am a Class 11 Humanities student preparing for CLAT. I have good speaking skills, but I am nervous about public

speaking and get easily influenced. I often feel tense about handling college life and dealing with manipulative people. How do I overcome these challenges? Sakshi

Dear Sakshi,
It is normal to feel anxious and tense about college while still in school. You should only care about doing well, learning and enjoying the experiences in college, not about judging yourself and overthinking before anything happens.

You are very young and impressionable, and it is easy to get influenced and swayed by others.

So, identify your core values and use them as your guiding light when you form friendships and other associations. Trust your gut and do not sign up to anything on the spot because of persuasion and pressure.

Work on the pros and cons of every decision and then get back to people and choices. This will help you make informed decisions and keep you safe.

Consciously create distance from people who could be manipulative. You do not need to please anyone, especially if you feel confused or drained after interactions. You do not owe them any, so don't feel scared or overwhelmed.

Be comfortable in your own skin and work on your self-esteem. Engage in a daily healthy routine that helps you stay grounded and balanced and convert nervous energy into structured expression.

My cousin is finishing B.Tech Computer Science

from a tier-3 college and is concerned about poor placement prospects. He wants to work in a field that uses Python. How can he get a good job? Poojitha

Dear Poojitha,
A tier-3 college does not block good careers in technology any more.

Python-based career options are in demand. He can look at entry roles as a Backend Engineer, Junior Software Developer or be a Data Analyst, Business Analyst, Automation/Python Scripting Engineer, QA Automation Engineer, or DevOps.

Let him work and strengthen his core foundations in Python (loops, OOP, file handling), Data Structures and Algorithms (basic), SQL, Git + GitHub. These decide interview survival, not certificates.

He needs to pick one track across Backend Developer, Django/Flask, Data Analyst, Pandas and SQL or Automation, Selenium and PyTest. Each has its own specifications.

He must work on building three to four solid GitHub projects. Internships are more important than placements. He should actively apply to startups and for contract roles or remote internships across LinkedIn, Internshala, Wellfound (AngelList Talent), or GitHub issues (open source).To crack interviews, let him practice Python problems daily (LeetCode/HackerRank) and communicate with clarity to get the edge.

Disclaimer: This column is merely a guiding voice and provides advice and suggestions on education and careers.

The writer is a practising counsellor and a trainer. Send your questions to eduplus.thehindu@gmail.com with the subject line Off the Edge



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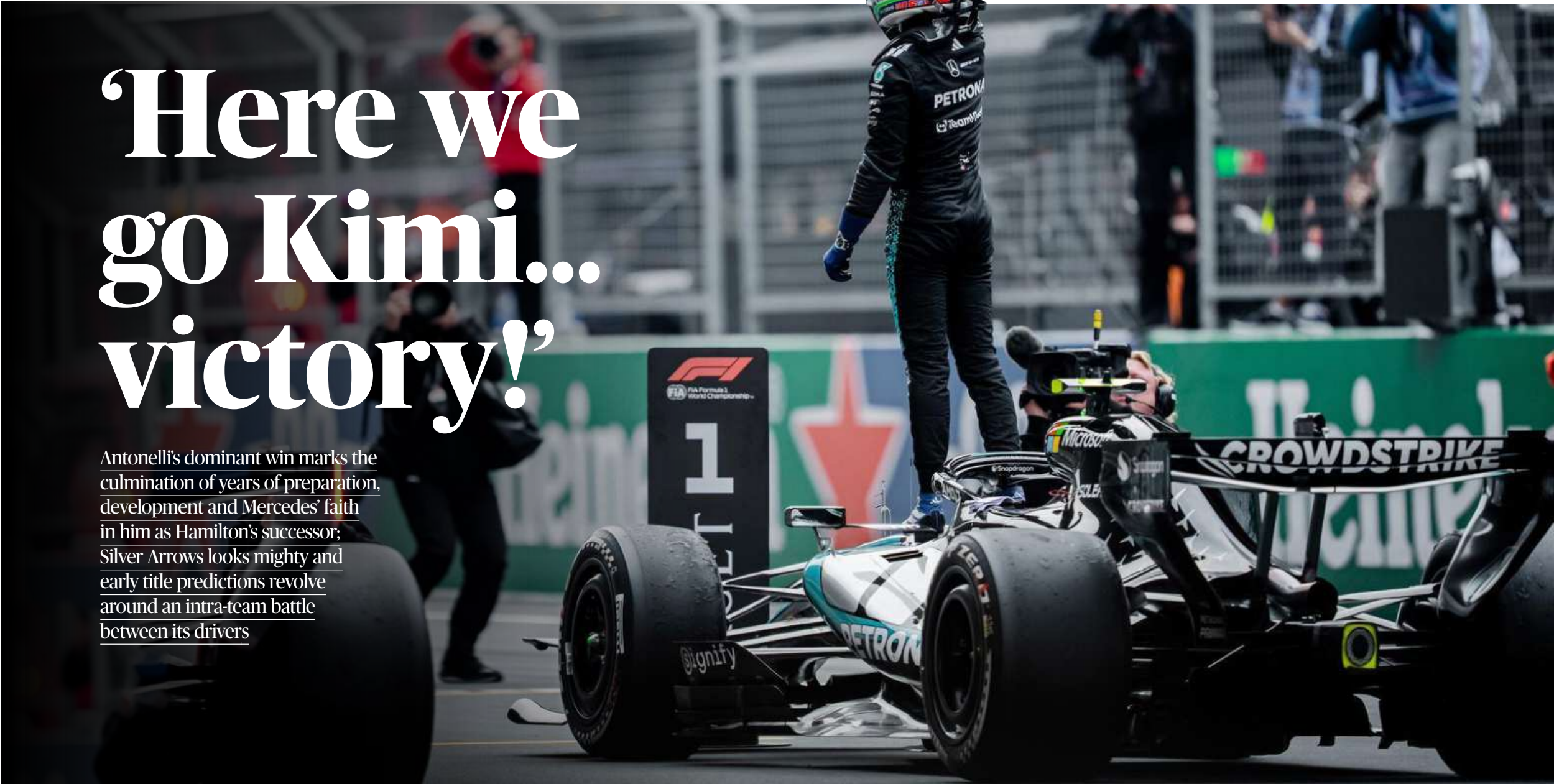
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‘Here we go Kimi... victory!’

Antonelli's dominant win marks the culmination of years of preparation, development and Mercedes' faith in him as Hamilton's successor; Silver Arrows looks mighty and early title predictions revolve around an intra-team battle between its drivers



GETTY IMAGES

Anirudh Velamuri

Amid the emotional celebrations after Kimi Antonelli crossed the finish line at the Shanghai International Circuit, Mercedes team principal Toto Wolff delivered a message to the doubters - clear, direct, and unmistakable.

“He’s too young. We shouldn’t put him at Mercedes. Put him in a smaller team. He needs the experience. Look at the mistakes he makes. ‘Here we go Kimi... victory!’”

For the first time in 504 days, the Italian national anthem echoed around the grandstands - and this time, it wasn’t Ferrari that prompted the Fratelli d’Italia.

Antonelli, the youngest driver ever to convert pole position into a race win, stood beaming between his teammate George Russell and the man whose seat he inherited, seven-time world champion Lewis Hamilton.

Foundations

To say this triumph was a long time in the making would be inaccurate. No one expected the 19-year-old to start winning races. However, the groundwork was laid in 2024, when Hamilton opted to leave Mercedes for Ferrari. Wolff later admitted he had not hesitated to identify Antonelli as the racing legend’s preferred successor.

“I made up my mind (about promoting Antonelli) five minutes after Lewis Hamilton told me he was going to Ferrari. Obviously, we were discussing other options, and obviously, the Max (Verstappen) idea couldn’t be discounted completely, looking at what happened at Red Bull. But instinctively, this is the line-up that I always wanted,” he had then told reporters.

So for Mercedes, this victory represents the culmination of years of investment. Antonelli was first identified in April 2019, while still racing in karting. Rapid progression has long defined his career. He won the Formula Regional European Championship in 2023. Rather than following the conventional route through Formula 3, he advanced directly to Formula 2 while simultaneously completing private Formula 1 tests across circuits including Austria, Imola, Silverstone, Barcelona, and Spa-Francorchamps.

Dominant win

On Sunday at the Chinese Grand Prix, Antonelli reinforced why Mercedes entrusted him with a top seat. In a remarkable qualifying performance, he claimed pole position - becoming the youngest pole-sitter in F1 history - outpacing Russell by 0.222 seconds.

Shanghai’s long back straight places a premium on clean air and tyre management. Starting from pole offers a crucial strategic advantage, particularly in controlling pace and pit windows.

When the lights went out, however, Ferrari responded as expected. Hamilton briefly snatched the lead, while Charles Leclerc overtook Russell. Antonelli, undeterred, reclaimed first place on lap two and prevented rivals from dictating strategy. From there, he controlled the race with maturity beyond his years. His only notable error came late on, when he locked up under braking and ran slightly wide. For a brief moment, Russell appeared poised to capitalise - but the mistake proved inconsequential. Antonelli crossed the line unchallenged. This was his defining moment, the



AP

realisation of a teenage dream. His emotion on the podium said everything.

“I’m speechless. I’m about to cry, to be honest. But yeah, thank you so much to my team because they helped me achieve this dream. I’m super happy. I said yesterday that I really wanted to bring Italy back on top, and we did today. Even though I gave myself a little bit of a heart attack towards the end with a flat spot, it was a good race.”

Two races into the new season and a pair of Mercedes’ 1-2s only strengthens early predictions: this year’s title fight is going to be an intra-Mercedes battle.

Hamilton finds his rhythm

Last season, in his dismal debut campaign with Ferrari, which featured a sole sprint win incidentally at this very circuit, questions emerged about Hamilton’s adaptation and longevity in the sport. On Sunday, the narrative shifted. He secured his first podium for the Scuderia after a spirited duel with teammate Leclerc.

A driver with a record 105 race victories describing the race as one of the most enjoyable of his career said everything about what this finish meant, underscoring that doubts about his waning competitive edge were premature.

“We’ve got a lot of work to do to try and keep up, but I had so much fun. It’s one of the most enjoyable races that I’ve had in a long, long time, if ever. The fact that the cars are the way they are this year and that battle with Charles at the end was awesome... great wheel-to-wheel battle, very fair and just what we want. There was one moment we did touch, but it was just a kiss, so it’s okay. But that’s what it’s about. It’s about tough racing.”

It was a compelling watch for spectators and Ferrari fans in particular, even if it aided Russell’s P2 finish. Team principal Fred Vasseur’s statement that the drivers are free to race was music to the neutrals’ ears, even if it comes at the expense of some elevated heart rates among the tifosi.

“I think it was under control; there was great respect between them. You are always a bit scared because something

can happen, but in the end, it is very difficult to freeze positions on track. We were doing a good job and you couldn’t know what would happen at the end. I think it was the right decision. We also need this to grow as a team. It was a good battle, good for the team, good for Formula 1 and good for the fans,” Vasseur declared.

There is also hope that Ferrari might cut the gap to the Silver Arrows’ rocketship. “A package was planned for Bahrain, which we will bring to Miami. We will also look to bring other developments, maybe a package and a half.”

Giants fumble

While Mercedes is flying high, McLaren, which uses its power units, including the 1.6-liter V6 turbocharged hybrid engine and energy recovery systems, has spectacularly stumbled at the start of this era of revamped regulations.

While Lando Norris managed to race at the Australian GP after Oscar Piastri’s pre-race crash, both were consigned to their respective garages with the team failing to field both cars at the Shanghai International Circuit. The reason? Two separate electrical issues in the power units.

McLaren has attributed the gap to Mercedes and Ferrari on an “underdeveloped” chassis more than a power unit knowledge deficit. But whatever the issue may be, it needs to get its act together soon or risk being left behind before it can get to grips with its car. Next door, Max Verstappen has struggled to come to terms with his Red Bull Racing car, which lacked grip throughout the weekend. He managed to qualify P8, but yet another dreadful start saw him on the back foot from the get-go.

In typical Verstappen fashion, he fought his way through the field once he put on the hard tyre and was sitting in P6, behind Ollie Bearman’s Haas, before a cooling problem on the energy recovery system then prematurely brought his race to an end. The Dutchman has long been grumbling about this new era of

battery-dominated racing, and the events of Shanghai will only amplify his protests.

That Bearman (17) has bagged more points than world champions Norris (15) and Verstappen (8) shows how much both teams have been struggling, not to discount the good work Haas has put in to give the youngster a strong platform to showcase his abilities.

For all the early hype about Adrian Newey turning Aston Martin into one of the front runners, the opposite has been the reality so far. It is comfortably the worst car on the grid, well behind newcomers Cadillac.

Lance Stroll’s car gave up after nine laps while Fernando Alonso was forced to retire after the 32nd. Both drivers are trying to find solace in humour. Stroll asked for divine intervention ahead of the Japanese Grand Prix, the home race for engine supplier Honda, while Alonso waved to Sergio Perez’s Cadillac as it cruised past him.

The videos of Alonso resorting to letting the steering go after struggling with the car’s vibrations has amplified calls for the team to prioritise driver health over all else.

Much better offering

While the Chinese Grand Prix weekend was far from perfect, it was a much better offering compared to the dull race in Australia. Yes, the cars still lack power halfway down the long back straight. Yes, there was ample lifting and coasting (Turns 6, 9 and 11). Yes, the battery continues to have a strong impact when it comes to overtaking. But it is not all doom and gloom, especially if the energy concerns are addressed. There was ample overtaking, even if the majority of it was between Leclerc and Hamilton. It was entertaining overall, cheeky comparisons to Mario Kart notwithstanding.

The accusations that this era will not reward the best drivers are untrue, even if the biggest differentiator remains the quality of drivers’ machinery. For the discerning racing enthusiast, that might be the most crucial footnote from this weekend in Shanghai.

THE GIST

- While Mercedes is the front-runner, Ferrari continues to be the second best, with Hamilton ending his long wait for a maiden podium with the Prancing Horse
- The others, meanwhile, struggle. McLaren runs into technical issues, while Red Bull and Verstappen encounters reliability issues
- Criticism of the new regulations takes a backseat momentarily as Shanghai witnesses overtaking and competitive racing

Ice patches on melting glaciers greater threat than thought: ISRO scientists

Researchers have found that the presence of exposed ice patches on the Srikanta Glacier immediately before the flood in Uttarakhand on August 5, 2025, was a signal of ongoing deglaciation and a direct indicator in the landscape of the likelihood of such floods

Meena Menon

A new study by scientists from the Indian Space Research Organisation (ISRO), published in *NPJ Natural Hazards*, examines the August 5, 2025 flash flood that destroyed Dharali village in Uttarakhand and killed six people. It sheds light on how warming temperatures affect glaciers, especially exposed ice patches on retreating glaciers, and highlights the need to monitor glaciers using satellite images to provide early warnings of possible disasters.

The study, titled ‘Ice-patch collapse and early-warning implications from a Himalayan flash flood: emerging cryo-hydrological hazards under deglaciation’, concludes that the collapse of an ice patch on the glacier above Dharali is linked to deglaciation in the Himalaya.

The authors say the findings could help improve understanding of climate risk and disaster preparedness. The study shows that the flash flood was triggered by the collapse of an ice patch in the nivation area of the Srikanta glacier.

Nivation is defined as the erosion of the ground beneath and around a snow bank, primarily as a result of alternate freezing and thawing. This can form a nivation hollow, which gradually becomes deeper when snow repeatedly accumulates in the same place.

History of extreme events

The study area lies in the upper Bhagirathi river basin in Uttarkashi district of Uttarakhand. It covers the ridge-to-valley system from the Srikanta glacier to Dharali village, located at a height of 2,650-2,700 m along the Bhagirathi river. The village lies downstream of the glacier-fed Khir Gad stream, which originates from the Srikanta glacier, flows through Dharali, and then joins the Bhagirathi river. The Khir Gad divides Dharali into right- and left-hand bank settlements, increasing its risk of flash floods.

The region has a documented history of extreme events, including the large landslides that brought down massive boulders during the June 2013 Himalayan floods. The researchers used satellite observations, high-resolution topographic analysis, and visual records to reconstruct the sequence of events linking unstable glacier ice to the sudden flood.

The findings expand the range of recognised glacier-related hazards in the Himalaya and identify exposed ice patches as an under-recognised risk from glacier melt.

The Dharali event also shows how instability in the cryosphere can create hazards downstream in high-altitude regions.

The study calls for closer monitoring of glaciers and argues that the focus should



A screenshot shows houses being swept away after heavy rains triggered by a cloudburst at Dharali, Uttarkashi district, Uttarakhand in August 2025. PTI

extend beyond glacial lake outburst floods (or GLOFs) to include smaller, often overlooked instabilities in the cryosphere. The exposure of ice patches in the Srikanta glacier before the flood represents a transitional state in the snow-ice regime. “Pre-event imagery during the ablation period revealed exposed ice patches on steep north- to northeast-facing slopes, indicating thinning seasonal snow and firn cover consistent with ongoing deglaciation,” the authors wrote in the paper.

Such exposure indicates thinning seasonal snow and firn, which is ice that lies between snow and fully formed glacial ice. It usually occurs when warmer conditions reduce the insulating snow layer that stabilises the ice beneath.

Ice patches covered by firn and seasonal snow are relatively resistant to short-term temperature changes whereas exposed ice is more likely to shift or loosen. Because exposed ice responds more quickly to temperature changes or heavy rainfall, it can melt, fragment or collapse more easily, releasing ice, meltwater, and debris that can trigger flash floods.

Therefore, the study finds that the presence of exposed ice patches on the Srikanta Glacier immediately before the floods of August 5 was a signal of ongoing deglaciation and a direct indicator in the landscape that increased the likelihood of such floods.

Satellite observations

Srikanta Glacier is a small- to medium-sized valley glacier with a height of 6,133 m, around 9.8 km upstream of

Nivation is defined as the erosion of the ground beneath and around a snow bank, primarily as a result of alternate freezing and thawing. This can form a nivation hollow, which gradually becomes deeper when snow repeatedly accumulates in the same place

Dharali. The glacier has steep accumulation and ablation zones, seasonal snow cover, and extensive nivation areas. Mountaineering and expedition reports describe unstable ice surfaces, steep slopes, avalanche-prone terrain, and persistent nivation zones beneath the ridge below the Srikanta peak, the paper said.

A key implication of the study is that it shows the value of pre-event satellite observations for early warning. Satellite images showed exposed ice patches persisting in the nivation zone during the ablation period, when the glacier loses ice and snow. This indicated that the seasonal snow and firn cover had thinned.

Studies from other cold regions, including the Canadian Arctic and Greenland, also show that the collapse of ice patches can trigger hazards as glaciers lose more ice and snow due to regional warming.

Identifying nivation hollows

Although rarely reported from the Himalaya, events such as the February 2021 Chamoli rock-ice avalanche demonstrate the growing prominence of cryospheric hazards in deglaciating

terrain, the study said. In steep nivation hollows, such instability can suddenly release ice, meltwater, and debris, triggering downslope mass movement and related cryo-hydrological hazards.

The Dharali flash flood illustrates how cryospheric instability can trigger geomorphic changes and create hazards downstream in high-altitude Himalayan regions. The study finds that the rapid disintegration of an exposed ice patch in the nivation zone of the Srikanta glacier was the main cause of the event.

The reconstructed sequence, from the exposure of the ice patch during the ablation period to its disappearance and the resulting downstream impacts, shows how earth-observation data can help identify and reconstruct such extreme events in remote mountain terrain.

“A broader implication of this analysis is the identification of nivation hollows as geomorphologically sensitive zones for cryospheric instability,” the authors concluded.

“Persistent snow and ice retention on north- to northeast-facing slopes below the Srikanta ridge created conditions conducive to ice-patch exposure and subsequent failure during the ablation season. Similar settings are widespread across the Himalaya, suggesting that systematic identification and monitoring of such zones should form part of regional hazard assessment and disaster-risk reduction strategies in the context of ongoing deglaciation (Meena Menon is an independent journalist, researcher and author. She has a PhD from the University of Leeds. meenamenon@gmail.com)

THE GIST

A key implication of the study is that it shows the value of pre-event satellite observations for early warning

Satellite images showed exposed ice patches persisting in the nivation zone during the ablation period, when the glacier loses ice and snow. This indicated that the seasonal snow and firn cover had thinned

Studies also show that the collapse of ice patches can trigger hazards as glaciers lose more ice and snow due to regional warming

The study calls for closer monitoring of glaciers and argues that the focus should extend beyond glacial lake outburst floods to include smaller, often overlooked instabilities in the cryosphere

BIG SHOT



An Amazonian turtle (*Podocnemis expansa*) at Jau National Park, located in the Anavilhanas archipelago in the Amazon rainforest, in Amazonas State of Brazil, on Saturday. Riverine communities and scientists have released around 1,500 turtles into the environment as part of a programme to assist the reproduction of the species. AFP

WHAT IS IT?

Trisulphide metathesis: new avenues

Vasudevan Mukunth

Researchers at Flinders University in Australia and their partners recently reported in *Nature Chemistry* a new way to swap sulphur-sulphur bonds. They found that organic trisulphides, which are molecules containing a chain of three sulphur atoms, undergo a spontaneous reaction called metathesis, where they trade parts with each other almost instantly.

The ability has important applications. The researchers used it to modify a fragile anti-cancer drug called calicheamicin without damaging its complex structure. They also used the reaction to create a new type of plastic. Because the sulphur bonds can be broken as easily as they are formed, the resulting material is chemically fully recyclable. As a result, manufacturers can build long polymer chains to create a solid plastic, then use the same reaction to unmake it back into its original starting materials. The discovery is important because it happens at room temperature without any extra help. Usually, breaking sulphur-sulphur bonds requires intense heat or light or strong catalysts. But the reaction only needed a specific type of solvent, such as dimethylformamide, which is already widely used in industry, to start the process. The reaction is also fast, often requiring only seconds. The team also explained how this reaction works. While most sulphur



The new trisulphide metathesis reaction can spontaneously make and break sulphur-sulphur bonds at room temperatures GETTY IMAGES

reactions traditionally use unstable radicals or ions, it uses a temporary, high-energy molecular arrangement called a thiosulphoxide. This ‘chemical pathway’ allows the molecules to swap their parts quickly and precisely, producing only pure trisulphides without any side products or unwanted chemical mixtures.

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Text & Context

THE HINDU

NEWS IN NUMBERS

Israel's emergency Budget allocation for military purchases

827 in \$ million. Israel has approved an \$827-million emergency Budget allocation for military purchases, Israeli media reported on Sunday. The 2.6-billion-shekel package was approved over the weekend by Cabinet Ministers, the daily *Haaretz* reported. AFP

Number of passenger journeys handled by Delhi Metro in 2025

235.8 crore. Delhi Metro handled a whopping 235.8 crore passenger journeys in 2025 with an average daily ridership of 64.60 lakh passengers daily, the Delhi Metro Rail Corporation (DMRC) said in a statement on Sunday. PTI

Persons arrested in Iran over suspected links to Israel

20 Iranian authorities have arrested at least 20 people in the country's northwest on suspicion of cooperating with Israel, local media reported on Sunday. The arrests took place during raids on networks linked to Israel in the West Azerbaijan province, the Fars news agency said. AFP

IS detainees transferred by the U.S. from Syria to Iraq

5,700 Iraq warned that drone attacks near Baghdad airport threatened the security of the nearby prison housing Islamic State group suspects brought from Syria. In February, the U.S. completed the transfer of 5,700 IS detainees from Syria to Iraq. AFP

Amount by which NHAI increased its annual pass fee

75 in ₹. The National Highways Authority of India on Sunday said it has increased the rate of its annual pass by ₹75 to ₹3,075 for the next 2026-27 financial year. The annual pass facility was launched on August 15, 2025. PTI
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Why is the U.S. investigating India?

What allegations has the U.S. made on excess capacity and forced labour? How do the two Section 301 investigations relate to the current U.S. tariff regime? What issues are the U.S. investigations examining and why do industry experts see them as a pathway to new tariffs?

EXPLAINER

T.C.A. Sharad Raghavan

The story so far:

Over the last week, the U.S. government has launched two investigations against India and several other countries in a bid to find some form of actions or policies that “are unreasonable or discriminatory and burden or restrict U.S. commerce”. These investigations will likely take a few months, but could eventually result in the return of tariffs.

What is the current situation on tariffs?

The U.S. Supreme Court on February 20 ruled against the validity of U.S. President Donald Trump's use of the International Emergency Economic Powers Act (IEEPA) to levy reciprocal tariffs on America's trade partners. For India, these reciprocal tariffs had been 50% from August 2025 to February 6, 2026, after which Mr. Trump reduced them to 25%.

Following the court's decision, Mr. Trump imposed a 10% tariff on imports from all countries for a period of 150 days under Section 122 of the Trade Act of 1974. He threatened to increase this to 15%, but has not done so.

However, he said the U.S. would use other sections of the Trade Act to levy additional tariffs.

What was the first investigation?

On March 11, the office of the U.S. Trade Representative (USTR) said it had initiated investigations against 16 economies, including India, to see whether these economies were using excess manufacturing capacity to export to the U.S. in a manner that was hurting American businesses.

The order for investigation under Section 301(b) of the Trade Act included specific allegations against the economies



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named – China, the European Union, Singapore, Switzerland, Norway, Indonesia, Malaysia, Cambodia, Thailand, Korea, Vietnam, Taiwan, Bangladesh, Mexico, Japan, and India.

In India's case, the U.S. said the country had a bilateral trade surplus with it of \$58 billion in 2025. Indian government data, however, shows that India had a merchandise trade surplus of \$42.2 billion with the U.S. over this period.

“India's global goods trade surplus sectors include textiles, health, construction goods, and automotive goods,” the U.S. order said. “For example, evidence suggests the solar module sector is plagued by excess capacity, including that India's current module manufacturing is nearly triple annual domestic demand.”

It added that India has created “significant excess capacity” in petrochemicals, steel, and other industries.

What is the second investigation about?

A day later, the USTR announced the launch of a fresh investigation, this time

on 60 countries, including India. The fresh investigation was to look into whether these countries had taken “sufficient steps” to prohibit the import of goods produced with forced labour and how the “failure to eradicate” these practices impacts U.S. workers and businesses.

This investigation, too, was under Section 301(b) of the Trade Act of 1974.

Why is Section 301(b) significant?

Section 301 of the Trade Act of 1974 is aimed at addressing unfair foreign practices affecting U.S. businesses. Notably, according to the website of the USTR, “Section 301 may be used to respond to unjustifiable, unreasonable, or discriminatory foreign government practices that burden or restrict U.S. commerce”.

According to trade and industry experts, this “response” that has been allowed in the law is the pathway through which the Trump administration could once again levy tariffs on imports from other countries once the 150-day window for his current 10% expires.

“While its [the investigation's] impact on India's exports will be clear only after

the investigation concludes, it seems the move is aimed at imposing a new tariff once the 150 days for the 10% global tariff expires,” Pankaj Chadha, chairman of the Engineering Exports Promotion Council of India, said.

How did the Indian government respond?

So far, it has not responded publicly. In contrast, the European Union has already spoken strongly about it.

“We will be seeking further clarity from the U.S. on how the opening of this section 301 investigation would interact with” the EU-U.S. agreement signed last year, European Commission spokesman Olof Gill said. “The commission would respond firmly and proportionately to any breach of the joint statement commitments,” he added.

How have Indian industries responded?

Mr. Chadha said that this fresh development comes over and above the existing tariffs that the steel, aluminium, auto, and auto components sectors still have to pay. The U.S. has implemented a separate 50% tariff on the import of these goods, including from India, which continues even after the Supreme Court's order.

Similarly, the Confederation of Indian Textile Industry has said that the recent developments add further uncertainty to the textiles and apparel sector, which it said is already under significant stress due to the developments in West Asia and a lack of clarity over how the U.S. tariff situation will unfold.

Ravi Sam, the Vice Chairman of industry body Texprocil, however, said there is no need for panic as these investigations will be long, drawn-out processes and will not have any immediate impact. This sentiment was echoed by trade expert and former Director General of Foreign Trade Ajay Srivastava as well.

THE GIST

The U.S. has launched two investigations under Section 301 of the Trade Act of 1974 against India and other economies to examine practices that may be ‘unreasonable or discriminatory and burden or restrict U.S. commerce’.

One probe examines whether countries, including India, are using excess manufacturing capacity to export to the U.S. in a manner that hurts American businesses, while another looks at whether countries have taken ‘sufficient steps’ to prohibit imports of goods produced with forced labour.

Why is Rajasthan's property Bill drawing scrutiny?

How will the proposed law regulate property transfers in notified areas? What concerns has it triggered?

Saeed Pande

The story so far:

The Rajasthan Prohibition of Transfer of Immovable Property in Disturbed Areas Bill was passed by the Rajasthan Legislative Assembly on March 6 in a voice vote. The Bill seeks to regulate property transactions in areas that the government declares as “disturbed”. However, the legislation has sparked debate over its constitutional validity, potential misuse, and its broader social and economic implications.

What does the Bill propose?

Under the proposed law, Section 3(1,2) states that the State government may declare any area within the State as a ‘disturbed area’ if it considers that communal violence, riots, or public disorder exist or are likely to occur.

According to Section 5(1,2), once a locality is notified, any transfer of immovable property, including land, houses or commercial establishments, would require prior approval from the

District Magistrate or Collector. This restriction applies to transfers by sale, gift, exchange, lease, etc. Property transactions carried out without such permission would be treated as legally invalid. Section 7 empowers the District Magistrate or Collector to conduct an inquiry to determine whether the proposed transfer is voluntary and genuine, or whether it involves coercion, intimidation or a distress sale.

Under Section 9, the law also provides penalties for property transfers carried out without the required permission. Section 10 includes provisions aimed at protecting tenants from forced or unlawful eviction in such sensitive areas. Violations of the Act (Section 12) are treated as cognisable and non-bailable offences, punishable with three to five years of imprisonment and a fine.

How does the Gujarat model compare?

The Rajasthan Bill draws comparisons with the Gujarat Disturbed Areas Act, which has its origins in a 1986 ordinance passed after severe communal riots in

Ahmedabad. The law was first enacted in 1991. It was later strengthened through amendments in 2020. The law was introduced to prevent distress sales of property by minorities who, after repeated communal riots in cities such as Ahmedabad and Vadodara, felt compelled to leave their neighbourhoods and sell property at low prices.

In Ahmedabad, a large share of the Muslim population is concentrated in Juhapura, often described as the largest Muslim ghetto in western Ahmedabad, limiting the community's geographical spread. In the context of the 2020 amendments, the then Chief Minister Vijay Rupani said publicly that the intent of the law was to ensure that Hindus and Muslims remain within their own areas and do not exchange property.”

What are the legal and constitutional implications?

Even though the right to property was removed as a fundamental right by the 44th Amendment to the Constitution in 1978, it remains protected under Article 300A, which states that no person can be

deprived of property except by authority of law. The proposed legislation provides such authority by requiring government approval before property in notified “disturbed areas” can be transferred.

The Bill has also drawn attention in relation to Article 14, which guarantees equality before the law. Legal observers note that if the provisions disproportionately affect certain neighbourhoods or communities, the law could face scrutiny on grounds of arbitrary classification or discrimination.

What are the Opposition's concerns?

Congress questioned the Bill's communal bias. Moreover, real estate transactions in notified areas could slow down because each transfer would require administrative approval from district authorities. They also point out that vague terms such as “disturbed area” or “demographic imbalance” may leave room for broad administrative discretion. There are also concerns about the arbitrary classification of disturbed areas, the ghettoisation of communities, potential discrimination in government services, and the distortion of representation. As a result, the policy, though intended to prevent forced displacement, has been criticised for institutionalising residential separation and communal polarisation, while reinforcing existing communal boundaries in housing markets rather than promoting integration. (Saeed Pande is a freelance writer with a focus on politics, current affairs, international relations, and geopolitics)

THE GIST

The Rajasthan Legislative Assembly has passed the Rajasthan Prohibition of Transfer of Immovable Property in Disturbed Areas Bill to regulate property transactions in areas declared ‘disturbed’.

While the government says the law will provide administrative oversight and prevent coercion or distress sales, critics warn it could increase bureaucratic oversight, allow arbitrary classification of disturbed areas, and reinforce communal segregation in housing markets.

